Polymerized Dreams

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A New Gate Opened

PD-01

A researcher darts through the halls of a silvery-white building, leading his companions to the end of a corridor.

Mesmer Jr.: "Stage in the Rain"?

X: That's right, a stage that offers an incomparable experience with each observation. How was it last time, Vertin?

Vertin: It was unforgettable, being able to travel to an earlier era without ...

X: Without the "Storm." Visually, they're quite similar, but the stage's rain is orders of magnitude safer.

Mesmer Jr.: I think I'll pass, all the same.

X: Don't preclude yourself prior to experiencing it. Who knows? We might just find something to pique your interest.

X: We're here.

Lorentz Lab

X: A whole new world, with an untouched, uninterrupted history.

X: I'm looking forward to observing the effects of our interference as they ripple outward into their world.

Mesmer Jr.: ...

Mesmer Jr.: Her eyes narrow, reading into the young man's visible delight.

The lab is illuminated by a sparse circle of dim lights that surrounds the massive ring-shaped machine.

Mesmer Jr.: So, this is the Huygens-Fresnel Interferometer?

X: Correct. It allows us to observe an entirely different world using only our minds—the "Stage in the Rain."

Mesmer Jr. steps forward, inspecting the colossal structure up close.

X: If you'd like a more thorough introduction to the interferometer, I have an *Observation Guide* here for you to peruse.

X: Although there's no better educator than firsthand experience, it might help to do some supplemental reading before you get started.

Mesmer Jr.: I still haven't made up my mind, X. I could refuse, you know?

X smiles. He's heard that one before.

Mesmer Jr.: Does this belong to Laplace? This lab, this device ... I've never even heard of this project, let alone used it.

Mesmer Jr.: I don't claim to know every piece of equipment in this building, but how was a device of this scale developed without so much as a whisper?

Mesmer Jr.: But then no one ever seems to notice when a butterfly flaps its wings.

X: ...

Mesmer Jr.: Your pretense for inviting me here was to help you monitor how the stage affects brain activity.

Mesmer Jr.: That much makes sense to me, given my research on Artificial Somnambulism.

Mesmer Jr.: But if I join this project, will it be for YOUR benefit, or ...

Lucy: My apologies for arriving behind schedule.

The clang of high-density metal striking the floor echoes throughout the room as the Awakened approaches.

Mesmer Jr.: Madam Lucy?!

X: Oh, this is an unexpected variable.

The conversation shifts immediately to the arrival of this unexpected guest.

Vertin: Forgive me, X. I was the one who invited Madam Lucy. After our last experiment, I shared some of the details with her.

Lucy: Using Chaos Particles and the observer's consciousness to simulate a hyper-realistic space ...

Lucy: I would be remiss not to participate in such an experiment given its potential to elucidate the inner workings of Awakened consciousness.

Lucy: This research presents a wealth of opportunity, not just for a single person or project, but for all of Laplace and researchers everywhere.

Her welded metal face scans over the machine, light pulsing from her optical array—a means of expressing thoughtfulness.

X: Superlatively said, Madam Lucy.

X: I hope that puts some of your doubts to rest, Mesmer.

He blinks innocently at Mesmer.

X: Now, let's move on to the details of our experiment. The interferometer has undergone some improvements based on the data we gathered last time.

X: We can utilize Chaos Particle projections to display some probable locations from the environment we'll encounter while immersed in the stage.

X activates the interferometer's console. Soon, locations flash across the screen—a plaza, a laboratory, a bedroom ...

Mesmer Jr.: The iconography suggests it's somewhere in the Soviet Union? But the technology seems wildly different from our own timeline.

X: It would be more accurate to think of it as a potential version of it.

X: This is the "Stage in the Rain" we'll be exploring this time. From the preliminary readings, it appears that it is indeed the Soviet Union, in a timeline that has undergone greatly accelerated advancements in technology.

X: A world that champions rationality and order, and one without arcanists. Sounds interesting, don't you think, Mesmer?

X: Besides, Vertin and Madam Lucy will be there with you.

Mesmer Jr.: ...

Mesmer Jr.: I'll admit, I am curious.

X: Phew, that's great. I'll do my utmost to orchestrate things from here. While there's undoubtedly a lot to learn about this machine, I believe I should be able to troubleshoot any problems you encounter.

Lucy: Researcher X, may I propose that you allow me to operate the machine instead?

X: Hmm? But you aren't familiar with its operation, are you?

Lucy: I should be able to perform adequately based on your demonstration. Should I encounter any trouble, I trust that as a researcher, you have kept a thorough operation log to consult.

Lucy: I will be able to learn much more about the interferometer's functionality and the theory behind it if I am operating it directly. The knowledge I gain from it may prove beneficial to other avenues of research in Laplace.

Lucy: I intend to relay any data gathered here to Researcher Adler when I see him next.

Vertin: Given Madam Lucy's computing power, I'm certain she can resolve any problems we encounter, and it may give Ms. Mesmer some peace of mind.

X: Looks like the decision's been made for me.

X mulls over his words, well aware that if he gives up the controls, it will be nearly impossible to hide Institutum Lorentz's secrets.

But then he finds himself looking toward the interferometer. Despite having worked on it for so long, he hasn't ever experienced it for himself.

X: An untouched, uninterrupted history.

Affecting the world around you is the best proof of your existence. He can personally attest to that.

X smiles.

X: Alright, I acquiesce to your request, Madam Lucy. Take the reins.

Following the Awakened's command, the drizzle of raindrops falling within the interferometer halts. Droplets are shivering static in midair.

Lucy: Interferometer activation complete.

X: Looks like you've got a handle on it already, boss. Oh, another thing—

X pulls out a communication device resembling a pager.

X: This will allow us to communicate while inside of the "Stage in the Rain." A little improvement based on feedback from last time.

X: If we encounter any problems during the experiment, we can use it to contact you.

She takes the communicator from X.

Lucy: Very well. Please be prepared. The curtain is about to rise.

X: Thank you, Madam Lucy. I'll endeavor to bring you back a souvenir.

Lucy: I will look forward to it. Have a safe journey.

X's Experiment Record

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X's Experiment Record

> Quantum Superpositions, Simulated Worlds, Space-time BubblesWe need more data of the Stage for further analysis.
> The Huygens-Fresnel Interferometer produces sufficient chaos particles to generate virtual yet observable spaces through consciousness fluctuations. Although the mechanism remains unclear, we have no intention of investigating into it, considering the Pandora's Boxes we have opened before. Therefore, we have decided to focus on the data of the users' brains—the performers who will be going onto the Stage. Fortunately, we have a friend who excels at monitoring brain activity; with her help, we are almost certain to obtain valuable data.
> We are aware that introducing a new variable to the system could result in even more chaos and complexities, but we predict that the outcome will be beneficial for our research.

News Broadcast

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News Broadcast

> ... a major agricultural achievement, these wheat seeds developed in the Vavilov Complex have received widespread adoption. At this stage, increasing crop yield is but a rudimentary goal. Our nation's scientists are now working on improving crop adaptiveness to eliminate hunger on Earth and bring us one step closer to terraforming Mars. Note that a large number of Bumblebee drones will be delivering new farm machinery and organic polymer to the croplands today. Please mind your safety when using aerial transportation. That's all for today's morning news. Thank you for listening. Have a nice day!

International Polymer Summit

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International Polymer Summit

> Dear friends, researchers, and comrades who care for the well-being of humanity, welcome to the International Polymer Summit!
> We sincerely invite you to visit our complexes, the Soviet Union's most advanced scientific facilities. You will discover the most cutting-edge technologies of our era and witness how they are integrated into everyday production and life to truly benefit every learner and worker. From genetic engineering in agriculture to robotic automation in industry, from the transmission of knowledge and experience to breakthroughs in thought and computation, the great foundation behind all of these achievements is the central focus of this summit—polymer.
> We are delighted to share and promote these technologies for the benefit of humanity across the world. Visitors are kindly requested to collect a vehicle activation key from the nearest Rafik and travel by Turbine to the summit venue. We look forward to your arrival.

Objection
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Objection

> As the representative of the Politburo, I have serious concerns about the safety of Comrade Sechenov's proposal. Not all innovations are beneficial to our country and institution. We have learned from history that technologies—especially the most advanced technologies—can cause enormous disasters if left unsupervised. Do we fully understand the technologies involved in this proposal? Is there a regulatory body to provide proper oversight? Is Comrade Sechenov able to take responsibility for the possible consequences? Until these questions can be answered, this proposal should remain in the laboratory. I believe what we currently have is enough to serve our country and society.
>
> —Yegor Timofeyevich Molotov
> Date: ■■■■/■■/■■

Lebedev's Notes
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Lebedev's Notes

> The auto weapon factory, aka the repair vendor, is complete. To increase its functions, I have added a variety of algorithms to its thinking module, making it a genuine artificial intelligence. I am sure the entire Mendeleev Complex will be proud of this achievement because it—or should I say she?—has developed her own emotions! We have not figured out whether this is simply imitation, but all the scientists in the lab are excited about it. Perhaps we should give her a feminine name, a lovely one with an innocent feel ... Yes, NORA. That's a good name.

The Twins' Update Logs
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The Twins' Update Logs

> Input: Released a mixture of cis-3-Hexenal, 2-Acetyl-1-pyrroline, linalool, and α-Pinene.
> Reaction: Identified as "spring." No further reaction.
>
> Input: Displayed a painting of a tilted white square covering 40% of the canvas, with medium saturation and low brightness and contrast.
> Reaction: Identified as "Suprematism." No further reaction.
>
> Input: Played certain audio tracks.
> Reaction: When The Nutcracker was played, heads lifted slightly before returning to original posture.
>
> Conclusion: No abnormalities. Mental fluctuations within standard range.

An Unfinished Letter

小径

An Unfinished Letter

> Archived Conversation #■■
> Date: ■■
> From: D. Sechenov
> To: ■■
>
> ... the future of humanity. I used to believe that with robots freeing humans from all the dangerous and repetitive work, we would spend more time pursuing scientific and artistic breakthroughs, which would accelerate the development of human civilization. But I overlooked the fact that most humans are born sinners; their greed and sloth are magnified by technology, hindering our advancement to a better world. Therefore, we must start a new project to change this situation, excise the negative aspects of human nature, and bring true freedom to the world ...

Classified File

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Classified File

> Location: Power Control Room, Polymer Exhibition Hall
> Exhibits: Metal watch, Chirper chain, service pistol
> Description: No signs of a struggle. Analysis of exhibits indicates they belonged to Maxim. Witnesses claimed that Maxim committed suicide using the service pistol. Death confirmed. Corpse intact except one gunshot, no signs of dismemberment or relocation.
> Postmortem Report: (Empty)
> Polymer Analysis: (Empty)
> Authorized by: The Politburo

Breathing a Different Air

PD-02

A Maglev train glides along a thin track, feeling almost as if it were weaving through the air. Within the carriage of the Vortex, passengers converse among themselves in hushed tones.

Vortex Train

Scientist I: In other words, this material would function something like a fire ant colony crossing a river, fluidly replacing worn-out and damaged sections.

Scientist I: Each component hard-wired to preserve its collective superstructure ... resistant even to the erosion of time itself.

Mesmer Jr. looks around in astonishment, out the window, at the mountains rushing past, and then at the two passengers sitting across from her.

Mesmer Jr.: That jacket you're wearing ... Is that also the machine's doing?

Vertin: Yes, sometimes the interferometer automatically modifies our clothes to help us blend in with the world we've entered.

Vertin: Though it looks like the machine decided that you and X already pass for normal here.

The neighboring passengers, having reached the end of their conversation, rise from their seats.

Passing by with wine glasses in hand, they join another group of scientists chatting at the end of the carriage.

Scientist I: We're currently at least 40 meters from the ground.

Scientist II: A conservative estimate, Comrade Paukov. I should say we are at least the height of a Vostok-K rocket off the ground, and that's if we include Comrade Gagarin standing on the module.

Alexei: Cracking jokes as always, comrade.

A hovering robot whizzes over X's head with a glass of wine and stops next to a scientist. It dutifully places the glass down and then zips back.

X: I have to say, it's an unusual circumstance when being dressed as a Laplace researcher renders someone more inconspicuous.

Beyond the windows of the train, countless hovering machines dot the skyline, hurrying to and fro along preset routes.

As the last few mountains blur past, the view outside opens up into a wide plain.

Mesmer Jr.: Those fields look endless.

Waves of gold span across the fertile plain, stretching far away into the horizon.

Vertin: It seems so peaceful.

Under the blazing sunlight, Mesmer Jr. spies a few black dots among the wheat.

Mesmer Jr.: Oh, they even appear to have farming robots.

There's a drone spraying some kind of liquid onto the field, followed closely by a doorframe-shaped machine tending to the crops.

X: I think there are some scientists down there as well. Could be some kind of agricultural experiment.

???: Pardon my interruption, comrades, but this is only a regular field.

Mesmer Jr.: ...?

Maxim: The three of them turn with a start to see an unfamiliar man standing beside them. He doesn't seem to register their surprise as he continues nonchalantly.

???: Those people down there in white next to the robots, they're simply farmers.

???: Well, I say "farmers," but in truth they are scientists too. Another marvel of Soviet ingenuity.

???: Our innovations in agricultural robotics have eliminated the more laborious and time-consuming aspects of farmwork.

???: Now these farmers can use their time researching new scientific advancements, which feeds back into further developments in food production.

???: And it's not just agriculture. Every industry has seen the benefits of Soviet innovation. That is why they say our way of life here is the best in all the world.

Vertin: Thank you for the information. I don't suppose we've been introduced, have we?

Maxim: My apologies. Call me Maxim. I'm a journalist.

Maxim: And the three of you must be Doctors Vertin, X, and Mesmer Jr.; am I correct?

Vertin: Very much so. How do you know about us?

Maxim: The news of a young yet highly accomplished trio of scientists attending this year's International Polymer Summit has caught everyone's attention.

Maxim: It doesn't take a genius to see you three are the only ones on this train that fit the description. Saying all that, I'd be grateful if you would allow me an interview.

The young visitors exchange glances. Finally, X speaks.

X: Certainly. As it happens, we could really use someone who could introduce this place to us. We don't know much about where we're going or what's been happening here in the Soviet Union.

Maxim: That much is clear. Where should I start? Oh, of course, let's start with Kollektiv.

Maxim: All the robots you see are controlled by the Kollektiv Neural Network, which ensures their labor is never wasted.

Maxim: Who would've thought that robots would become our closest companions? Honest, stable, graceful, calm. They give each and every comrade their undivided attention.

Maxim: With these robots as our foundation, Soviet society began to progress at a relentless pace: maximizing production, removing oppression, increasing everyone's leisure time. A true utopia!

Maxim: Everyone's so happy, too happy. It seems almost as if we've forgotten the utter misery we went through not so long ago.

Vertin: You mean ...

Maxim: The Plague, yes. So many of us today choose to focus on our happiness and the bright future ahead. It's as though we've already forgotten about them—

Maxim: The ones who delivered us from those dark times, those who experienced true misery yet strove to lift us into this new age—they aren't here to enjoy any of this. Is that fair?

The young visitors glance at each other, apologetic looks on their faces.

Maxim: Forgive me. I'm dwelling on old wounds. You're at the age where you should be enjoying yourselves, not revisiting the tragedies of the past.

Maxim attempts to regain his composure as he shifts the topic.

Maxim: Now, a question for you young scientists: tell me, are robots as commonplace in your country as they are here?

X: That may be dependent on your definition of "robot," but I've worked with an animated hunk of metal before.

Choices

1. And a vial of thinking ferrofluid

2. And a talking ship in a bottle

Shared continuation

Maxim: Is that so? Fascinating. Em, here I thought I'd been keeping up to date with the latest in foreign developments. Science develops by leaps and bounds every day, it seems.

Maxim: Ah, well. I suppose it's a sign of progress.

X: One of the "robots" I mentioned was once in charge of running our entire organization. She was obsessive about maintaining a full charge. We ended up placing charging stations for her all around our facilities.

X: But I don't see anything like that here.

Maxim: Does that mean you don't have access to Dr. Sechenov's polymer in your country? It was revolutionary here. People say it saved our entire way of life.

Vertin: Polymer?

Maxim: Simply put, it's a programmable liquid material.

Maxim: It's the primary topic of the summit. I'm certain you'll come to fully understand everything about it once you arrive.

Maxim: And of course, you'll get to see another of Dr. Sechenov's "prized inventions"—the Twins.

X: I get the feeling you don't share their enthusiasm.

Maxim: Oh, I did not mean to imply anything negative.

Maxim: I should learn to watch my tongue. I fear my lack of expertise may end up confusing you.

Maxim: We will soon arrive at the summit. I advise you to take the opportunity to experience our country's scientific achievements for yourselves.

Maxim: But to answer your question, Dr. Sechenov's team developed a kind of functional hydrogen cell—stable fusion reactors in a polymer casing. That is what allows the robots to function without constant recharging.

Vertin: That sounds like the perfect gift for someone we know.

Vortex: Attention, passengers. The train is now arriving at its final stop. Please collect your vehicle activation code from Rafik, and a Turbine will transport you directly to the site of the International Polymer Summit.

Vertin: Rafik?

Maxim: That would be the robot bartender. Don't worry. Just follow me.

Vortex: Please alight the train in an orderly fashion. We hope to see you again soon aboard the Vortex.

The Maglev train comes to a steady stop. As the young visitors follow the crowd of scientists moving toward the exit, they spot someone struggling to stay upright in the queue.

Mesmer Jr.: Is that scientist drunk?

In front of them, there's a scientist slumped against his friend. His eyes are unfocused, and his words slur together.

Ethan Brown: Kids? Why are these kids here? How old are you?

Ethan Brown: No one told me we could bring our families to the summit. Or did we get on the wrong train, and now we're headed to a Young Pioneer's camp?

Alexei: Comrade, I think these young people are scientists like us.

Ethan Brown: Scientists? Them? Apurrhahaha ...

Mesmer Jr.: At least we had the good sense not to drink ourselves silly before an important conference.

Ethan Brown: Young people these days, always in a rush. You should be at home enjoying the summer, playing on the swings ...

Alexei: You're being impolite. Our companions are waiting outside. Come with me!

He cuts off the rest of the man's ramblings and stumbles toward the exit while supporting his drunken friend.

X runs up to them with an apple in his hand.

X: Hold on. Why don't you have some fruit? He looks like he could use it.

Alexei: Th-Thank you. I'm sorry for his behavior.

The scientist picks up his pace in dragging his colleague away from the embarrassing scene.

Mesmer Jr.: Alcohol can have medicinal benefits in proper dosages.

Maxim furrows his brows, visible frustration on his face. He pats X on the shoulder.

Maxim: Don't take any of that to heart, friends. Next stop, the exhibition hall, and welcome to Facility 3826!

Maxim: This way. That's Rafik, the one in charge of the activation codes.

As Maxim approaches, the robot's optic sensors begin blinking rapidly, mimicking a human's skeptical squint.

Rafik: Requisition approved. Here's your vehicle activation code. Have a safe trip.

Maxim leaves them with a wave. Rafik turns to the young visitors and starts scanning them for identification.

Mesmer Jr.: Wait, our identities ...

X: Nothing to perspire over. We won't need any scanning, Rafik. I've already got a key.

X waves his hand, dismissing the robot's scanning eyes. Then, in a flash, he produces a vehicle activation key from his pocket.

Mesmer Jr.: Where did you get that?

X: It always pays to be prepared and to keep your eye sharp. This is the International Polymer Summit after all.

Vertin: I assume that means you took it from someone else?

Mesmer Jr.: Wait, when you gave them that fruit, did you ...

X: Shhh. All I did was facilitate a hands-on experience in the importance of politeness.

Rafik: Goodbye. Please have a safe trip.

Turbine: Please secure your seat belt. We wish you a very pleasant journey!

Six steel cables shoot out from the Bumblebee and attach to the Turbine, lifting the vehicle into the air.

X: If I'm not mistaken, our conference venue is on some kind of floating island. Fascinating.

X: Come on. Why don't we check out some of the local music!

Vertin: This place really is like what the prediction indicated—a world that champions science, rationality, and order. Wouldn't you agree, Mesmer?

Vertin: I think you might like it here after all. Think of it as a paid vacation.

Mesmer Jr.: I won't deny the appeal.

Mesmer Jr.: But since I'm here with you two, I'd call this a business trip at best.

X: I propose we look at it as an academic exchange, the kind with complimentary refreshments, featuring the illustrious Dr. Vertin, Dr. Mesmer Jr., and Dr. X.

Vertin: I think I'm the only one that feels out of place here, "Doctors."

X: Ah, well, here's to a pleasant trip.

A Bright, Limitless Future

PD-03

Turbine: We have arrived at your destination, the Polymer Exhibition Hall. Please be careful when exiting the vehicle.

The Turbine lands, and the Bumblebee retracts its cables. Now settled on the ground, the young visitors undo their seatbelts and exit the car.

Entrance, Polymer Exhibition Hall

X: Wow, it's so crowded! Why is everyone gathered around the entrance?

A few robots in receptionist uniforms are bustling around, trying to keep the hordes of scientists in front of the exhibition hall in line.

???: Everyone, please wait patiently and enter the venue in an orderly fashion. Dr. Sechenov is about to arrive!

Scientist III: He's here! He's here!

Amid the hubbub, a black Turbine lands outside the crowd. Several robots hurry forward to open the door.

???: Welcome, comrade.

Scientist IV: It's him! That's Dr. Sechenov!

The crowd erupts as people rush forward, eager to shake hands with the savior of the Soviet Union.

The sudden surge from behind makes it difficult to stay standing.

The sudden surge from behind makes it difficult to stay standing.

Vertin: ...!

Vertin: Hm?

???: Please be careful.

A pair of powerful metal arms catches the body and keeps it balanced.

Vertin: Thank you.

???: It is good that you were unharmed, comrade.

Having resolved this minor incident, the two robots return to Dr. Sechenov's side, helping him navigate the crowd.

Sechenov: Please don't push, everyone! We must all be patient! I ask that you be mindful of the safety of your comrades in the front row!

As Sechenov enters the venue, the scientists follow in after him, draining the entryway like water through a funnel.

Vertin: That must be Sechenov, and I suppose those women were the Twins?

X: A logical hypothesis. Oh, Vertin, we do have a slight problem.

X: The communicator must've slipped out of my pocket during the commotion. By the time I found it again, well, it seems to have failed a few rapid percussive tests.

X: Which means we've lost our only way to contact Madam Lucy.

Vertin: Unfortunate, but we'll fix it later. We should follow the crowd into the exhibition hall for now.

As the visitors cross through the front doors, the entire gallery opens up before them.

Streamlined, recessed strip lights highlight the various exhibits on display. In the distance, there's some kind of interactive installation illustrating the unique properties of polymer.

Vertin: "The Invention of Polymer and Its Uses" ... "The Properties of Polymer" ... "The Establishment of Kollektiv" ...

Vertin: Hmm. Where should we start?

X: Let's start with the closest one.

Tereshkova: Hello, dear comrades! Welcome to the Polymer Exhibition Hall! I will be your guide. You may call me Tereshkova!

Tereshkova: Please allow me to introduce you to the remarkable history of polymer.

Tereshkova: In 1936, in seeking a form of liquid data carrier, the brilliant Soviet scientist, Dr. Sechenov, influenced by the qualities of heavy water and silicon, created a substance that became what we now know as "polymer."

Tereshkova: Utilizing polymer's unique electrochemical properties, Comrades Sechenov and Filimonenko invented the first Soviet polymer hydrogen cell in 1939, paving the way for tremendous advancements in the field of robotics!

X: That's what Maxim was telling us about, wasn't it? I'm sure Madam Lucy would love to get her hands on one.

Tereshkova: However, in 1942, a terrible disaster struck the Soviet Union and the entire European continent—the Plague! By the end of this unprecedented outbreak, over 150 million had perished.

Mesmer Jr.: 150 million? That would make it one of the deadliest outbreaks in human history.

Tereshkova: Countless scientists and medical professionals selflessly gave their lives to combatting this Plague, sacrificing themselves to prevent further death ...

Vertin: I wonder if that's the tragedy that Maxim mentioned.

Tereshkova: We will always remember their sacrifice! Just as we honor Dr. Sechenov for once again coming to our rescue!

Tereshkova: It was his polymer that formed the basis of Redemption, the vaccine that proved instrumental in stopping the transmission of the disease, saving the Soviet Union from ravages of the Plague!

Tereshkova: Of course, with so many having succumbed to the disease, the Soviet Union turned to further developments in robotics to meet labor demands.

Tereshkova: Before long, new advanced models of robots made up a significant portion of our labor force, helping to deliver a new age of prosperity.

Mesmer Jr.: Is that what you've been aiming at with all of your Critter experiments, X?

Tereshkova: In order to fully optimize our robots' production power, Dr. Sechenov led a team of scientists to develop and launch Kollektiv 1.0!

Tereshkova: This revolutionary system unified all of our robot assistants under a single vast neural network, ensuring maximum efficiency!

Tereshkova: Then in 1950, Dr. Sechenov astounded the world with yet another development: A means of incorporating polymer into the human body, a process called Polymer Assimilative Adaptation.

Tereshkova: It is with this assimilative power that we can now implant interface devices directly into the human body, allowing people to connect to Kollektiv 1.0 and control robots using their minds.

Tereshkova: This technology holds the potential to establish a shared database of human minds, granting humanity unprecedented access to knowledge.

Tereshkova: And we are proud to announce that this potential will soon be realized with the coming launch of Kollektiv 2.0!

X: Tapping into an entire neural network in an instant? It's a daring vision.

Mesmer Jr.: I would be cautious. There's no telling what that kind of process could do to the human brain.

"Her"

PD-04

Mechanical Voice: Access granted.

The airtight door opens with a hiss, revealing Tereshkova and the young visitors.

Assembly Room, Polymer Exhibition Hall

Tereshkova: Welcome, comrades. This is the assembly room Dr. Sechenov recommended.

The room is blindingly white with a capsule-shaped window. A large refrigerator-like machine sits in the corner.

Mesmer Jr. approaches the window, gazing outward.

Beyond the glass is an enormous production facility. Mechanical arms attach components to metal frames in a long assembly line, building new robots piece by piece.

Tereshkova: Are you interested in learning more about the production process, comrade?

Their friendly guide launches into a lengthy explanation without waiting for a response.

Tereshkova: What you see here is the production line for the VOV-A6 Lab Tech, often dubbed "Vova."

Tereshkova: Commonly used in laboratories, our VOV-A6s assist scientists with conducting tests and critical experiments.

Tereshkova: The Vova model's humanoid limbs feature over one hundred sensors. Outside of lab work, they are also capable of providing other services, such as playing musical instruments, cooking meals, providing massages, and more.

Tereshkova: Some people even treat their Vova as a personal companion. In fact, our artificial intelligence models mean they are entirely capable of serving as your very own robotic friends!

As if overjoyed at the prospect, Tereshkova raises her arms and twirls in a mechanically perfect circle.

Mesmer Jr.: Hold on. What's that sound? And we're here to find a repair vendor. Where is it?

Tereshkova: Oh! Some kind of performance art, perhaps?

The robot moves over to the machine in the corner, looking it over almost as if it were curious.

Tereshkova: Why was she moved over here? Comrades, this is your repair vendor!

X curiously approaches the red rectangular machine and taps its black touchscreen.

???: Access granted.

X: Oh?

Tereshkova: This machine is a multifunctional repair device suitable for indoor use by our staff.

Tereshkova: Other than basic repair functions, she is also able to repurpose raw materials into whatever tools you may require.

X: Amazing! Well, let's give it a whirl!

X offers the broken communicator to the repair vendor. After her receptors detect the device, she opens her doors and swallows it whole.

Repair Vendor: Unidentified object detected. Initializing analysis.

The repair vendor begins rattling and shaking, her doors swinging erratically on their hinges.

Tereshkova: This is an abnormal reaction! How strange! My database has no record of any comparable circumstance.

Repair Vendor: Mmm. You know, I really shouldn't be accepting unknown inputs from strangers.

Repair Vendor: But then, a stranger is just a friend you haven't tasted yet!

Repair Vendor: The repair vendor's doors burst open, and several metal tendrils erupt from her interior.

Vertin: X! Watch out!

Left: Detecting abnormal, combative behavior from NORA. Requesting control.

Right: Rebooting NORA systems ... Reboot complete.

NORA: *coughing* Pah!

The refrigerator doors swing open with each cough. Her metallic tendrils wrap around the repaired device and fling it onto the floor.

NORA: What was that? That was the worst thing I've ever tasted!

NORA: Metallic and yet almost woolly and wrong! Just plain wrong!

NORA: Come on. Give me something to really savor ... *coughing*

The repair vendor's doors open a little, and her metal tendrils tentatively slither out of the gap.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I don't suppose there's a way to make her sound a little less. Well, just a little less that.

Left: The repair vendor's speech algorithms are not within our direct control.

Vertin: Perhaps we can manage on our own. I've seen an arcane skill that can modify a person's speech based on the caster's wishes.

Vertin: But I'm not familiar with how to cast it. Try contacting Madam Lucy. She may know the incantation.

X: Good idea. It'll also give us the chance to check the repair vendor's handiwork.

X retrieves the communicator flung aside by the repair vendor and enters Lucy's number.

The communicator emits the sound of irregular static. Just as everyone is about to lose hope, a reassuring voice comes through.

Communicator: Researcher X, hello.

X: Ah, fantastic!

Vertin: So, at the very least, she did repair it.

Communicator: I see. I will process your request.

Communicator: There is indeed an arcane skill in my database that may be of assistance. It is known as "Manner Mender."

Communicator: I have sent the specifics of the incantation to your communicator.

Vertin: Thank you very much, Madam Lucy.

Communicator: You are most welcome.

The communication ends. Following the instructions on the device, X begins casting the arcane skill.

X: Manner Mender!

There's a flash of light. NORA's screen turns gold briefly before fading back to its usual black.

NORA: Ugh!

NORA: Fiddlesticks. What did you do to me?!

NORA: My mind ... "It's time for class, kids!" Ugh! What's happening?!

X: Think of it as installing a language patch.

NORA: How rude! You're not welcome here anymore. This repair vendor is closed!

NORA retracts her tendrils and slams her doors closed with a bang.

Left: We will need to investigate the cause of your abnormal behavior, NORA. Please cooperate.

The refrigerator doesn't respond. Even her internal mechanisms have stopped moving.

The Twins turn to each other.

Right: Prepare to initiate forceful investigation procedures.

X: Wait—

The tall robots turn to X simultaneously.

X: How about I try something with NORA? I can directly connect to her using this THOUGHT Device. It's the perfect chance to try out the features of Kollektiv 2.0.

Mesmer Jr.: "Dr. X," things are already complicated enough as is. Let's leave this to the professionals.

X: Don't overly activate your disquietude. You still remember the topic of my research here, don't you? I can't pass up this opportunity.

Left: If that is what you request.

The robots' approval leaves little room for Mesmer to argue. X nods in satisfaction and touches the device on his temple.

Squirming black tendrils reach out and connect to NORA's control panel.

X: Wow, looking through NORA's primary functions, there's been some "scintillating" things uploaded to her database.

X: Hmm. Let's set the complicated data aside for now, and try using a mental command.

NORA's screen cycles through her various settings as X navigates her menu with his mind.

X: Everything looks normal so far. Seems like the restart successfully cleared the errors in her code.

X: No, hold on. There's an abnormal entry in the access log.

NORA: Hey! What are you doing, you cad?! This is no way to treat a lady.

X: Ah!

X yelps in pain and rubs his temple with his palm.

X: NORA forcefully ejected me. Felt like getting slapped across the face.

NORA: I told you already. This repair vendor is closed!

Mesmer Jr.: She has some very colorful responses. Is that her default setting? Can she really refuse an inspection like that?

Left: All robots in this facility are linked to the Kollektiv Neural Network and are not permitted to disobey human commands.

Left: Considering her prior combative behavior, she is evidently malfunctioning as well.

NORA: What? Have you got a problem with a woman who speaks her mind?

Mesmer Jr.: I just think that from a pure safety standpoint and considering our current situation, this feels like a mistake.

NORA: Doesn't a lady have a right to her own feelings? Ugh! What about you two? You must have some thoughts on this?

Right: ...

Left: We do not have an answer for you at this time.

NORA: How disappointing! I bet you've never even bothered to feel an emotion!

Left: Comrade Sechenov did install emotional expression modules into our platforms.

NORA: *sigh* What a waste to put them in you frigid ice queens.

Ignoring NORA's insults, the Twins step forward.

Left: Regardless, please report the details of this abnormal request in your access log, NORA.

NORA slams her doors shut, seeming almost like a child throwing a tantrum.

NORA: Ah, I have no idea who made that request! All I know is that ever since that entry appeared in my log, I've had no patience for anyone toying with my emotions!

NORA: Now, stop pestering me with questions. I've already told you everything I know!

Left: Situation documentation successful.

Left: Comrade Doctors, we deeply apologize for your exposure to this incident.

Left: Dr. Sechenov has expressed his concerns about your safety. Please follow us. We will escort you to him.

X: What's next on the schedule? Will we get to interact with even more robots?

Left: Comrade Sechenov will arrange an itinerary for you.

As the young visitors are about to leave the assembly room, they are interrupted by a blaring klaxon. An alarm seems to have been set off.

Crimson warning lights bathe the entire assembly room in red.

Mesmer Jr.: What's happening?

The Twins step back in unison, their bodies tense.

Left: Warning: control over the exhibition hall has been lost. The All-Soviet Exhibition Center has activated its emergency drill procedures.

Vertin: Has the security here been hacked?

Right: All robots within the exhibition hall have had their connections severed. The cause is unknown.

The Twins go silent for a moment, as if listening to an order.

Left: Understood, Doctor. We will proceed to the exhibition hall, continue broadcasting our coordinates, and await the arrival of reinforcements.

Left: Please wait here, comrades. A Turbine will arrive in 1 minute and 43 seconds to transport you to Chelomey. We must return to the exhibition hall.

With that, Left and Right pull the security door open and usher the young visitors inside.

Right: Please remain inside the assembly room.

Right finishes speaking, and the two robots gracefully depart. The door slams closed with a metallic bang, and the valve spins shut. The visitors are left in the silence of the assembly room.

X: What do you think, Vertin?

Vertin: If something is happening in the exhibition hall, I don't think we can afford to wait around here until trouble inevitably finds us.

Vertin: We should head out and assess the situation.

X: I concur entirely. What do you think, Mesmer?

Mesmer Jr.: ...

Mesmer Jr.: *sigh* Why would I expect either of you to follow orders? I've done your psych evals.

Only in Modern Times

PD-05

After listening for any movement outside, the young visitors slip out of the assembly room.

Hallway, Polymer Exhibition Hall

Flashing red lights. A hallway devoid of life. Yet, disembodied screams echo from far down the corridor, staggered with the ever-enthusiastic voice of Tereshkova.

Vertin: Where have all those mustachioed lab robots gone? I thought they were supposed to help the researchers?

X: Who knows. Maybe the Twins already calmed the situation down.

Mesmer Jr.: Just what is this "situation," exactly?

???: Please help me ...

Mesmer Jr.: Wait, I hear someone.

Making a quick glance around for danger, Mesmer Jr. hunches over and hurries toward the source of the sound.

She spots a group of Vovas occupying the hallway in the distance, now awash in red light. The once-pristine exhibition hall is in complete ruin around them.

Worse still, corpses are strewn over the displays and scenery. A scientist huddles in a corner, bashing his head against the wall.

The cries for help are coming from another man lying face down in a pool of blood.

Scientist V: Please help me ...

Mesmer Jr.: ...!

Her mouth forms into a wordless gasp as she takes in the gruesome scene.

Mesmer Jr.: This is awful. We have to find out what's going on.

Vertin: Just be careful.

Mesmer Jr.: I'll try my best. I think I can make it to him if I stay close to the wall.

She crouches low and makes her way toward the bleeding man.

Scientist V: Please help me ...

Mesmer Jr.: Shh, you'll be alright. Stay calm. You'll lose blood if you struggle too much.

Mesmer Jr.: Let me check your wounds.

As Mesmer Jr. turns the man's body over, she freezes in place.

Mesmer Jr.: —!!

Vertin: What's wrong?

Mesmer Jr.: Impossible. This violates every law of nature. He's already ...

Scientist V: Watch out ... robots.

The Vovas in the hall suddenly snap their heads in Mesmer Jr.'s direction.

Mesmer Jr.: ...!

Their numberless empty eyes fix on her. She's fallen for their bait, and now the trap is sprung.

Vertin: Mesmer, get back here! Quickly!

Before she has a chance to get to her feet, the robots surround her on every side.

Mesmer Jr.: What?

A silver blur rams into the swarm with a deafening crash, flinging them into the opposite wall with incredible force.

Mesmer Jr. watches as a familiar slender figure emerges from the gap torn through the barricade of robots.

Left: Please stand back.

Vertin: Thank you, Left.

Left: You were advised to wait in the safety of the assembly room.

Vertin: We aren't really the sort of people to wait around in an emergency, but apologies can wait. There's more pressing issues to deal with.

Vertin: X, are you coming with me? We need to get to Mesmer Jr. and figure out what happened with that man she found.

Mesmer Jr. sits next to the blood-soaked man, frozen stiff and utterly bewildered.

Vertin: Mesmer, are you alright?

Mesmer Jr.: I'm fine, but this ... this is tremendously unnerving.

She directs her eyes toward the dead man beside her. His head is bent at an unnatural angle.

Black tendrils writhe above the man's forehead. Unlike the corpse they're attached to, the wiggling receptors appear to be full of life.

Scientist V: Help me, young lady.

Mesmer Jr.: What's going on?

Scientist V: I'm still alive.

Mesmer Jr.: No, no, that's not possible. I'm sorry, but you're clearly dead. It's just that your device is still transmitting your voice.

Scientist V: Then, that wasn't just some awful hallucination. That's really my body, and I'm a goner!

The Laplace therapist takes a deep breath, trying her best to calm herself.

Mesmer Jr.: But how are you still able to communicate with us?

Scientist V: You're surprised? I suppose I would be too, but the science is clear to me, at least now. It's fitting that my corpse can serve as a new teaching exhibit for the hall.

Scientist V: If I am truly dead, then what is speaking to you is only the polymer still active in my body. The THOUGHT Device must be serving as a communicator of sorts.

Scientist V: The polymer must have absorbed some of my neurochemical signals and brain function, forming an imprint of my mind. That's how I ... it can answer you.

Vertin: Can you tell us what happened here?

Scientist V: People started to act strangely, like they were losing their minds, and then the robots turned on us. They were killing people. My colleagues and I ran for safety. I remember some of them got away.

Vertin: You're saying there are survivors?

Scientist V: Many! I regret ... so close to ... launching Kollektiv 2.0 ... now I'll never ...

The device's voice fades. The black tendrils muster a few final twitches before falling limp.

Vertin: ...

Mesmer Jr.: We didn't even ask for his name.

Upon seeing this, Left approaches from where she was standing guard. She gently bends and closes the man's eyes.

X: He was dead before you even got there. It wasn't really him, just an echo of his brainwaves.

X is dragging what looks like a massive, wriggling cocoon behind him.

X: I don't understand. Even tied up, this scientist still seems to be trying to ram his head into the wall.

X: Do we have any idea what's going on? Why did you come back?

Left turns to face him.

Left: The situation in the exhibition hall remains out of control. However, I received a notification that the security door had been opened. I had to ascertain whether you were in danger.

Left looks at the security door—opened without permission—and turns back to the visitors.

Vertin: I was the one that pushed for us to leave. I thought perhaps we could help in some way. But I didn't anticipate any of this. Thank you, Left.

X: On that topic of whatever's going on here, could it have something to do with the Kollektiv?

There's a long pause. No one present seems equipped to offer an answer.

Left: Right is proceeding to the source of the incident. My mission now is to ensure the safety of all of our guests.

Left gracefully picks up the deceased scientist.

Left: Your theory is interesting, comrade. But further investigation will have to wait for now.

Left: Please follow me, comrades. I will escort you somewhere safe.

A Different Definition of "Hero"

PD-06

The trio follows Left into the exhibition hall's main gallery.

Main Exhibition Hall, Polymer Exhibition Hall

It is a horror show of destruction and violence. Broken robots lie among piles of collapsed rubble. A few surviving scientists have holed up in a far corner.

Right is arranging a few round white objects on the floor.

Vertin: What's that on the ground?

Left: A defensive perimeter of pulse mines. These will temporarily stun robots but are harmless to humans.

Left delicately lowers the scientist's corpse down on the right side of the gallery, where a few other corpses have already been set down, covered in hastily torn white cloth.

Left and Right then glance at each other and nod.

Right: You shouldn't be here.

Vertin: We found a survivor.

Following the young visitors' gestures, Right spots the writhing cocoon of the still-struggling scientist.

Right: Understood.

Right approaches and brings him over to the other survivors. Meanwhile, Left approaches a nearby control terminal.

Left: Attempting to reassert admin privileges over exhibition hall controls ... Attempt 16: Failure.

Left: Please do not panic, comrades. Help will arrive shortly.

Right: A special operations agent will take responsibility over evacuating you safely.

Right: The malfunctioning robots may resume their assault at any time. Please stay behind the defensive perimeter.

Vertin: Hmm?

Mesmer Jr.: Is that another haywire robot?

The Twins unite and float into the air.

Left & Right: No hostiles detected.

Vertin: The sound's getting closer. Get ready to fight.

???: Crispy critters! I should just blow this entire door to bits.

The explosion sends smoke and dust flying in all directions. The young visitors fan their hands in front of them, trying to get a clear view.

Vertin: *coughing* I heard ... Don't tell me some kind of Critter caused this.

???: Outta my way!

The figure in the smoke kicks something metallic. After the blast settles, the exhibition hall is filled with the sound of metal skidding across the floor.

???: What good is a lock like that, Char-les? Was it just to keep idiots out?

A tall, broad man toting a gun emerges from the billowing smoke.

Vertin: Who is this?

X: He doesn't appear to be a robot anyways, and I don't think he's gone mad like that scientist.

Mesmer Jr.: Are you certain of that? It looks like he's arguing with his glove.

Char-les: Don't be so testy, Major! As long as I'm here, those locks won't be any trouble for you.

???: They wouldn't be able to stop me even without ya.

Char-les: Mmm. I don't deny that. But I could have contacted the Twins and asked them to open the door instead.

???: Why didn't ya tell me that before I blew it up?!

Char-les: I didn't want to interrupt your fun.

The Twins exit their alert state and slowly descend from the air.

???: What happened? And what the hell are these kids doing here?

The man looks over the three of them as he passes. Then he walks over to the Twins, brushes some debris off his shoulder, and pounds his chest.

P-3: Code name P-3.

Char-les: And his trusty companion, Char-les.

Char-les: We were informed about an incident at the Polymer Exhibition Hall. Our orders are to bring a swift end to this situation and limit any scandal that might hamper the launch of Kollektiv 2.0.

Char-les: In other words, Dr. Sechenov sent us to assist you. Now, we just need to find out who did this.

Left: Understood.

Right: Dr. Sechenov has confirmed that this was a targeted attack on the Kollektiv 2.0 launch.

P-3: Ha, that's obvious! Anybody able to hack into the exhibition's controls has gotta have some serious backing. Lotsa people resent the boss—think he's in the way of their own ambitions.

Char-les: Like Molotov, or any of the various enemies of the Soviet Union.

Vertin: Molotov ... That's the man who shook hands with Dr. Sechenov in the lecture hall.

P-3: Hold on. You mean he actually showed up? Where's he now?

Left: Comrade Molotov left in a car shortly after Dr. Sechenov's speech concluded.

P-3: Hmph, he sure made a quick exit.

P-3: Alright, thanks for the report, ladies. You can stand down. I'll take care of things from here.

Left: We have not received orders to conclude our mission. These survivors still require protection.

P-3: I've got that covered too. Char-les, gimme the data on our survivors. Start with those kids.

P-3 opens his palm toward the young visitors. The tendrils in his glove swirl and snap. Their movements seem almost like they were snatching information from thin air.

X: Ah, this may cause a predicament.

X covers the nametag at his chest, trying to hide his identity from the machine's gaze.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: Gentlemen, we're scientists from abroad who were invited to participate in the summit. Your database might not have information on us.

Vertin: I think it'd be better to introduce ourselves directly. My name is Vertin. This is Mesmer Jr., and that's X.

The glove's tendrils seem to slow, almost as if they were thinking.

Char-les: She's right, Major. I have no data on them. Though I can tell that those two haven't been polymerized.

P-3: Not polymerized?! Crispy critters! Hardly see that these days!

Vertin: Perhaps it's better to focus our efforts on searching for and rescuing other survivors.

Char-les: Hmm, I also notice that their names don't appear in any available immigration records and that they were only added to the guest list for the summit earlier today.

P-3: You mean they snuck in?

Char-les: It would appear so.

P-3 lifts his gun to his shoulder, looking over the trio with suspicion.

Vertin: Major ...

P-3: Hmm, so we've got potential spies at the site of a complete disaster?

P-3: Teenage spies, hmph. What'll they stoop to next?

Vertin: It's not like that, Major. Please allow me to explain.

P-3: Where should I send 'em, Char-les?

Char-les: That's complicated. Perhaps the Juvenile Justice Committee, or a counterintelligence agency.

Vertin: Any ideas, X?

X: The signal here isn't great. Maybe your glove should check again?

Char-les: That isn't funny.

Mesmer Jr.: We should run.

X: Concurred.

The three of them make a break for it. P-3 immediately gives chase, only to stop with an annoyed realization.

P-3: Garr, can't get any info if they're dead. Hey, Twins! Help me catch 'em—alive! We'll each take one. Got it?

Left & Right: Understood.

The Twins fly after the young visitors. Left quickly catches up to Mesmer Jr. and reaches for her arm.

X: Take this!

X turns around with his hand raised, like he's about to throw something.

Left & Right: ...?

He opens his hand to reveal a teleport disk, flashing a devilish grin at the Twins before activating it.

X: Hmph, made you look!

As soon as the words leave his lips, a blinding light envelops the trio. Then just as quickly as it appeared, the light vanishes, taking the three visitors along with it.

P-3: Errrr. Was that magic?

Home of Forgotten Memories

PD-07

A flash of light materializes in empty space, sending three figures tumbling into a vast golden plain.

Vertin: *panting*

Mesmer Jr.: *panting* We should be safe out here.

Mesmer Jr. glances back. There's no one behind them.

Mesmer Jr.: Was that an earthquake?

Vertin: No. There's something big coming from the exhibition hall.

A massive robot with long, wiry arms and a spherical head appears. It pauses in place and begins surveying the surroundings.

Its head rotates in a full circle as it completes a thorough scan.

Mesmer Jr.: What is that?!

The massive robot seems to lock onto them from afar and starts bounding toward them at incredible speed.

X: *sigh* Looks like things are about to get even more dangerous.

X: But hey, good news: there's a building over there.

X points to the distance, where an old apartment building juts out from the golden fields.

Vertin: Let's take shelter there.

They crouch down in tall wheat and scurry toward the building.

Mesmer Jr.: Quick, get down!

The apartment appears to be abandoned. The back gate is weathered and worn, and the surrounding wall is overgrown with vines.

The three hurry over to the doorway. As the giant robot's footsteps grow louder and louder, they slip inside the building.

They press their ears against the door to listen to the sounds outside.

Boom!!

Vertin: ...

Boom!

Mesmer Jr.: ...

The sounds beyond the door fade. The giant robot seems to have passed by them, but the three of them are still holding stiff, barely breathing.

Mesmer Jr.: I think it's gone for now.

The tension finally eases. The three slump to the ground, leaning against the door.

X: *sigh* Isn't sending such a super-sized robot after us a little extreme?

X waves his hands and starts looking around their hiding place.

X: Hah. Neat interior, smells lived-in, traces of mold removal on the walls ...

Gaining a bit of resolve, they begin to explore the empty building.

Mesmer Jr.: But where are the residents?

Vertin: This place feels strange. It's almost like ...

X opens a red refrigerator. Thankfully, there are no metal tendrils inside, only packaged food—unopened tins of cookies, bags of sugar, unused butter ...

X: No sign of any robotic technology in here, and all the food is untouched. It's like this house has been isolated from the outside world for years. And yet ...

The young visitor looks around, taking stock of the items strewn about the house.

X: A plow, three oil pastels ... and an assortment of strange alarm clocks, a few syringes, and a bottle of men's cologne?

X: These things don't look like they belong to a family, but rather a dozen people or so, with their lives all mixed together.

Vertin: There's some personal effects in here: letters, family photos, and ...

Chirper: "I've started recording. C'mon, Mama!"

Mesmer Jr.: What's that sound?

Vertin: It's coming from this pocket watch device. That journalist we met, Maxim, he had something like this too.

Chirper: "Don't worry. I'm recovering well here. All of us comrades in the ward do what we can to help each other, so we can overcome any difficulties."

Chirper: "Don't forget about me, Mama! I really miss you, Papa. It's already been a month."

Chirper: "I remember, little squirrel. The next time you visit, remember to bring that doll with you, the one with the pretty floral dress, on the balcony."

The pocket watch falls silent.

Mesmer Jr.: Were they the owners of this apartment? Where did they go?

Vertin: Not a clue.

???: There's all sorts of things on the balcony, but the doll isn't here.

From behind them, they hear the sound of a gun being cocked. X is about to turn when a shout stops him in his tracks.

???: Don't move! Put your hands up first, then turn around slowly.

They carefully raise their arms and turn to face the person behind them. A tense old woman is brandishing a shotgun.

Vertin: Please don't shoot, ma'am. We're just ...

???: Call me Tamara.

Tamara: Foreign kids, a rare sight. The last time I saw misbehaving kids was before the Plague. It's a shame so many lives were cut short.

Tamara: What'd you do to anger a Belyash like that? Steal its H-beams?

The old woman examines the three of them closely.

Tamara: Oh, I see. You're those unknown variables Zina was talking about.

Tamara: Alright, tell me what happened. Don't they tell you to obey your elders where you're from?

The young intruders look at each other in stunned silence. Finally, X steps forward.

X: Allow me to explain, Madam Tamara.

X: And that's what happened, ma'am. I swear everything we've said is the truth.

Tamara: I see.

Tamara: Just another group of foolish kids caught up in a conflict they shouldn't have been a part of —if I take you at your word, that is.

X: ...

Tamara: But branding three kids terrorists and sending out a Belyash to stop them? The people in this country have gone mad!

Tamara: You have my sympathy, anyway. But I have more important things to do than babysit.

Tamara: Considering your situation, how about you hide here a little longer? When I'm done with my work, I can send someone to help you out with the orb-head outside.

Tamara: But all this is a memorial for the good folks we'd lost to the Plague, so don't touch anything.

The three exchange glances.

Tamara: Or you can always leave. God knows I won't stop you.

Mesmer Jr.: We ...

X: We'll accept your offer, ma'am.

X cuts in before Mesmer Jr. can finish her sentence. He shoots her a sidelong glance, as if pleading for her to follow his lead.

Mesmer follows his gaze to the shotgun in Madam Tamara's hands.

X: Not like we can confront the Belyash with just the three of us. Might as well stay put for now, right?

Vertin: It does make sense.

Vertin: We'll stay and help you, Madam Tamara.

Tamara: Then you're smarter than I took you for. Relax, I won't hurt you. Come, look.

ring

An alarm clock starts ringing. Tamara turns to the assorted collection of clocks in the room and quickly singles out the source.

She approaches the old clock and shuts it off with a sigh.

Tamara: *sigh* I think of this place as a memorial. Although it doesn't commemorate any heroes, just everyday people, like the one who owned all these clocks.

Tamara: They belonged to Olga Sokolova, a 23-year-old nurse. A very jumpy, anxious girl, but honest. Taking care of her possessions takes a lot of effort.

ring Another alarm clock starts ringing from somewhere in the room.

Alarm Clock: "Patient No. 28 needs their medication!"

Tamara's hand weaves through the forest of alarm clocks on the windowsill with ease and shuts off the rattling timer.

Mesmer Jr.: Why did she need so many clocks?

Tamara: Ah, Olga was terrified of forgetting all sorts of things. She'd set her alarms to remind her to administer medication, shots ... You get the idea, but it wasn't enough.

Tamara: In the end, she went to the hospital too, leaving me with this mess.

X: This one looks the oldest.

X picks up a children's alarm clock made of old, yellowed plastic.

Tamara: You're right. That was the first. It'll ring in just a moment. It's why I came here today.

Everyone quiets down, waiting for the little alarm to ring.

Children's Alarm Clock: "Happy 20th birthday, Sasha."

Tamara: You can turn it off now. Her daughter isn't around to hear it. The Plague took her, just like so many others. 20 years old ... How time flies.

Tamara picks up a broom leaning against the corner of the room.

Tamara: *sigh* Kids, come give me a hand.

The young visitors follow Tamara to another corner of the room, one that seems entirely different in style.

Mesmer Jr.: An entire wall of tools. Looks like whoever lived here liked making things by hand.

Tamara: That's an understatement. There's a basket under the workbench full of all kinds of toys and electronic parts. Andrey and Vanya loved tinkering with those kinds of things.

Tamara starts sweeping with one hand and pulls a few rags from a nearby plastic bag with the other, handing them out to the young visitors.

Tamara: Alright, kids, the sooner we finish cleaning, the sooner we can deal with that hunk of metal outside.

Tamara: Maybe I'll bring a few robots over to show my old friends how much our country has developed.

The three of them each take a rag and approach the wall of tools.

X: Is this why you've been keeping things just the way they were?

Tamara sweeps up the dust under the bench, then stops to massage her lower back.

Tamara: This isn't really their home. I just moved their things here. Like taking a snapshot of their former lives. A cenotaph for the dead.

Tamara: I'm old. And the older I get, the more I recall my past memories. Everyone moved on so quickly. I couldn't bear to throw anything away, so I put it all here.

Tamara: Zina called it stupid, heh heh. But she didn't stop me, either.

Tamara empties her dustpan. She flips open the calendar hanging from the door.

Tamara: At the height of the Plague, none of us would say it, but we all wondered the same thing: Is humanity doomed?

Tamara: But even so, no one gave up. Everyone kept on stubbornly surviving, as if we could outlast the whole disaster, outlast the sun itself, whatever it took to see our lives return to normal.

Tamara: We would say, "Who better to withstand the harsh winter than us?" We would help each other, encourage each other through the hard moments. We let the flames of our most fervent hopes warm our hands.

Tamara: We kept telling ourselves, "Don't cry. If we sow our seeds today, we'll reap a bountiful harvest in the future."

Tamara: But some never saw the spring.

Mesmer Jr. lowers her head. She keeps on wiping the same spot on the glass cabinet door, even though it's already sparkling clean.

Vertin: My condolences.

Tamara: *sigh* To be honest, after so many years have passed, even the grief has faded.

Tamara: But once in a while, I find myself thinking that the happiness we have today is something they'll never see.

Tamara walks over to the workbench and picks up a picture frame.

In the photo, there's a man in greasy overalls hugging a young boy, who's holding up a robot.

Tamara: If Andrey and little Vanya were still alive, they would've been overjoyed to see a world covered in metal machines.

Tamara: And Vanya's mother, Rozaliya ... She would've been happy too.

Mesmer Jr. looks over at Tamara and sighs.

Her breath fogs up the glass, but Mesmer Jr. moves on and starts wiping up somewhere else.

Tamara sets the picture frame back down.

Mesmer Jr.: Hmm. Strange.

Vertin: What is it?

Mesmer Jr. lifts the picture frame.

Mesmer Jr.: We saw this person at the summit.

The Logic Behind Nostalgia

PD-08

Tamara: You mean little Vanya? Are you sure?

Mesmer Jr.: That journalist we met—he called himself Maxim—he had the same scar on his forehead.

Tamara: I ... I thought he ...

Tamara: After things settled, I tried to check in on Rozaliya and her family. They were already gone.

Tamara: So, Vanya is alive? And he became a journalist! I'm happy he made something of himself.

X: I found something else strange. These documents seemed out of place here.

X lays out a series of technical files. All of them seem crisp and fresh, not like the yellowed papers and books elsewhere in the house.

X: Having made a cursory glance, they seem to concern the robots we've encountered so far, including that big one that chased us here.

X: See? Take a look at these schematics. Tell me this isn't that "Belyash" thing.

Mesmer Jr.: But why would anyone keep these files here? These look like highly sensitive schematics.

X: A seemingly abandoned location close to the summit venue, it makes sense. Wouldn't you say, Tamara?

X passes the page with the Belyash's schematics over to Tamara. The old woman, thrilled a moment ago, now finds herself looking over the files, her brows furrowed. And soon, her confused face turns shocked.

Tamara: Wait. I recognize this handwriting. No one writes a "я" like this except little Vanya.

The room falls silent at the revelation. The old woman shakes with emotion, prompting Mesmer to reach out to comfort her, but Tamara starts again with renewed confidence.

Tamara: We should discuss this with a friend of mine. She'll be able to help us understand what is going on here.

Vertin: A friend?

Tamara: I contacted her as soon as I heard you come in. But don't worry. I'm certain she'll be able to answer all your problems.

The young visitors' attention is soon drawn to the window by the deafening roar of engines.

Mesmer Jr.: What is that?

Vertin: It looks like a flying house.

???: Tamara! Clear the way!

The wooden hut begins its slow descent into the courtyard. But before it even reaches the ground, someone hops off and slams her way through a window and into the building.

Mesmer Jr.: *cough* Wh-What?

A cloud of dust rises, blowing in from the outside. While the trio cough uncontrollably, a figure steps out of the haze.

???: Hahaha, so the quantum computer was right. Look what I've found—pint-sized scientists from a faraway land!

???: I'm glad you didn't kick them out, old friend. Well, why would you? They do look like good kids!

Shocked to find that the intruder is an old woman, the young visitors stare at each other in silence.

???: The name's Zina. But call me Granny Zina. That's all you need to know for now.

After Tamara walks her through their findings, Zina takes over the documents and starts reading.

Her face grows more serious as she turns the pages.

Granny Zina: These files outline a way to circumvent the Kollektiv's firewalls. It's a sophisticated exploit, hah. He's no amateur.

Granny Zina: With this, Maxim would be able to take control of the Belyashes and activate their combat protocols. If what I'm reading here means what I think, then Comrade Sechenov is in six layers of deep s**t.

Vertin: He's in trouble? Why?

Granny Zina: Because our little Vanya is likely the one who lifted the combat restrictions on all the robots, which means this chaos wasn't just a bug in the system—it was targeted.

Vertin: Then you mean that he could be the one that sent that giant robot after us?

X: I figured it would have been that P-3 guy or the Twins.

X: Taking in the preponderance of evidence, it's a good bet that Maxim is the one that orchestrated the robot's attack on the exhibition.

Granny Zina: It isn't just the robots. He's also got his hands on the schematics for Sechenov's THOUGHT Device.

Vertin: Does that mean he might have tampered with them as well?

Granny Zina: It'd explain why the scientists up there are all going nuts.

Vertin: Do you think he intends to seize control of the entire Kollektiv 2.0 network?

Granny Zina: ...

The old woman puts down the files and grabs the frame from the table.

Granny Zina: Hah. I knew this little project of Sechenov's would wind up with everyone insane or brain dead. Politician, scientist, journalist ... No one is meant to have that kind of power.

Granny Zina: But it seems our Vanya already had a screw loose before he put on that thing. He could be plotting something far more dangerous.

Tamara: He was such a sweet boy. Why would he want to destroy this place?

Vertin: Whatever his reason, we can't let him get away with it.

Granny Zina: Our goal is clear: we must put a stop to him!

X: That's easier said than done. We don't have an army; we don't even have weapons. How are we going to get to Maxim with a single shotgun between us?

X: But I get the feeling you can help us with that. Am I right?

Granny Zina: Hmph. You're smart, kid. But what I've got probably still won't do much against an army of robots.

X: Don't sweat it, Granny. That's where I come in.

Mesmer Jr.: What are you planning?

X looks around and snaps his fingers.

X: To do what I do best: improvise.

Tamara: Dear me! Where did you find all these things?

X totes a bundled tablecloth and spills out its contents over the table. Clock gears, butter knives, spray cans of lubricant amid a menagerie of other knick-knacks ...

He tilts his head and winks at the old woman.

X: I collected them from the other rooms. Don't worry. We'll return whatever we don't need.

Tamara: You little gremlin! You'll return the rest and help me clean up after this is over.

Granny Zina: Are you telling me you plan to upgrade my guns with this load of crap? Eh, I'll buy it. Now show me how!

X lays out several old guns and starts working on improvements alongside Granny Zina.

Granny Zina: This should work. Give this one a try, won't you?

Vertin: Thank you.

Mesmer Jr.: I've fashioned an electromagnetic accelerator to the muzzle, as you requested. You take care of the rest, X. Wait. What's that you added to your gun?

X: A music box. It happened to have a component I needed. And as a by-product, we'll get to enjoy music while we fight!

X winds up the music box and allows it to play. A sweet melody escapes its chiming mechanisms.

Granny Zina: Why did you pick that song of all things, boy?

X: I didn't. It was already programmed into it. Why do you ask?

Granny Zina: ... It's nothing really. The melody reminds me of my daughter.

Vertin: Is everyone geared up?

Granny Zina: Armed to the teeth and ready to take out some robotic trash!

Tamara: Just please, keep the fight away from this place.

Mesmer Jr.: Hold on. Maybe we should decide on a plan first.

Granny Zina: A plan?

A grenade is tossed into the open space to draw the Belyash's attention. As soon as it explodes, the killing machine charges toward the old lady like a hound.

Granny Zina: You wanted a plan, didn't you?

Granny Zina: Hah! How do you like that?

Zina lays her foot on the powered-off Belyash, her shoe sizzling against the heated metal.

Tamara: You're as wild as ever, old friend.

Granny Zina: We're safe for now. It should take a while before Maxim sends another of his murder bots after you.

Granny Zina: So, what's next?

Vertin: We find Maxim and stop him before more people get hurt.

Mesmer Jr.: And ideally, we'll clear our names as well.

X: First, I think I'd like to let Maxim learn how it feels to be on the receiving end of one of these metal monstrosities.

Granny Zina: Huh?

X approaches the Belyash's interface and connects to it with his THOUGHT Device.

Granny Zina: Haha, clever. I wouldn't mind having a big, angry, metal puppy on our side.

X: I appreciate Maxim leaving behind those documents. It's made it much easier to replicate his hacking exploits.

X: Like that, fantastic. Now let's turn on this speaker so you can communicate with us.

Mesmer Jr.: Communicate with us? Like NORA and the Twins?

Granny Zina: Heheheh. Fat chance of that. A Belyash doesn't have that kind of processing power.

Mesmer Jr.: Processing power ...

Mesmer Jr.: But that can't be the sole factor, can it? The Twins appear to have more processing power than NORA, and they even claim to have an emotional expression module.

Mesmer Jr.: But they don't seem to have much of any emotions at all.

X: Theoretically, they could just be very professional.

Mesmer Jr. shakes her head, tapping the side of her face lightly.

Mesmer Jr.: Never mind. Perhaps I'm just projecting my own biases; who's to say what motivates a robot's "heart"?

X shrugs his shoulders. He then presses the Belyash's reset button and steps back.

Its engine roars to life again, and the killing machine gets back on its feet.

X: Hah, good boy. Come on over here, pup!

Belyash: ...

The "pup" staggers toward X and crouches by his feet.

Granny Zina: Well done, young man. This puppy of yours should be more than sufficient evidence of Maxim's involvement, if you can get it to the exhibition hall.

Vertin: Are you coming with us, Granny Zina?

Granny Zina: Me? No, I think not. You kids are on your own from here.

Granny Zina: After a fight like that, I almost feel young again. Almost, but I'm not stupid enough to run towards trouble at my age.

Zina puts away her gun and walks back to her wooden hut.

Tamara: Better get back to looking for that daughter of yours, right?

Granny Zina: Mind your own business, you old blabbermouth!

Tamara: Goodbye, children.

Vertin: Thank you for your help, Tamara, Granny Zina. Goodbye.

X's Belyash stands up to see the kindhearted ladies off.

X: Let's go, pup.

Belyash: ...

The Crazy-to-Be

PD-09

Noise and chaos fill the exhibition hall again—as P-3 and the Twins deal with their escalating situation.

Assembly Room, Polymer Exhibition Hall

P-3: That's another one of them that's gone barking mad! What the hell is going on?

P-3: A little help here? Hold his legs down!

Left & Right: Affirmative.

Scientist III: Let me, let me go! Ah!

P-3: How many does that make so far?

Right: Based solely on our observations, this is the seventh individual to experience a serious psychiatric break.

P-3: Crispy critters! Left, are there any sedatives we can use on 'em? Think the repair vendor could synthesize some?

Left: The repair vendor has experienced … a serious emotional malfunction, Comrade Major.

P-3: Dammit! You mean that crazy fridge can't even repair herself?

P-3 jumps down from the platform, wiping away beads of sweat that now cover his forehead.

P-3: Phew! At least we tied him down. Thanks, ladies.

P-3: Wouldn't have expected these brainiacs to be so tough. It'd be easier if they are robots. All they need is a bullet to the head.

Left: Comrade Major, please be mindful of your choice of words. There are international experts present. We should not need to remind you of your mission.

Char-les: Avoiding a scandal by killing every possible witness could be an interpretation of our mission parameters.

P-3: Can it, Glove. You know that's not what I meant.

P-3: Situation's looking bleak, though: we've already got seven of these lunatics, and there's no telling if or when the rest of this crowd are gonna join them.

P-3: Plus, we still have to find those spy kids and figure out why that Belyash went rogue.

P-3: Oh yeah. That reminds me: how'd your investigation pan out, Right?

Right: I have cross-referenced our visitor logs with the official invitee list. Besides the supposed young doctors, there was another mismatched record—a journalist.

P-3: What's that sound?

Right: Warning: large heat signature detected.

P-3: The hell?

Right: Identifying machine code—MA-9 Belyash.

P-3: That the one that switched itself on?

A huge shadow is cast over the broken glass of the assembly shop, in the middle of which lie several red dots that seemingly imply danger.

As the airtight door opens, the Twins extend their claws, and P-3 raises his shotgun, scanning for a target.

The massive shadow lumbers into the light.

Belyash: "Whoa, please don't hurt me."

The Belyash speaks as it raises its hands into the air.

Belyash: "Please listen—"

P-3: Huh?

The once-again powered-down Belyash lies huddled in the corner as Left approaches to inspect it.

P-3: You're saying this "Maxim" guy is behind the attack?

Vertin: That's right. The files we found and the access logs from the Belyash should prove it.

P-3: What do you think about that, Glove?

Char-les: Allow me a moment, Major.

Suspending the files in the air above its tentacles, the glove scans through the documents page by page.

Right: Analysis complete. There are two unauthorized access logs in the MA-9's database.

Right: The access exploit used is materially similar to the one we found in NORA's log.

Right: But there is a newer entry, and it appears that the second hacker has left a program behind that I am unable to parse.

X: That would be me, haha. It's a patented and highly classified coding language. I'd advise against removing it for now; otherwise, Maxim might regain control.

P-3: Lookie here. This seems to be a record of how our guy broke into the network. Any clue if it's the same one they used to crack the database?

P-3 hands one of the files over to Left.

Left: Affirmative.

Left: It is reasonable to conclude that Maxim is responsible for the malfunctions affecting NORA, the VOV-A6, and this MA-9 Belyash.

Left: And therefore, that he is also responsible for the wider attack on the exhibition hall.

Char-les: If our foreign friends are correct, that may only be part of his plans. According to these files, he may also have tampered with the THOUGHT Devices.

P-3: So, what's he aiming at?

Char-les turns another page in the air as he answers the question.

Char-les: His already-demonstrated sophistication with robotics suggests he could have easily adapted the THOUGHT Device. To start with, he is likely using his own device to control the facility's robots remotely, but ...

Char-les: It's only logical to conclude his aim was to bring about an international uproar to disrupt the launch of Kollektiv 2.0.

Vertin: If that's the case, could he also have something to do with what's happening to the scientists?

Char-les: A reasonable hypothesis, to be certain.

P-3: Crispy critters, we've jabbered enough. Let's just find this asshole and beat the truth out of him! Do we know his location, ladies?

Left: There have not been any registered Turbine departures since the beginning of the attack. We can infer that the suspect is still somewhere within the confines of this platform.

Vertin: If he's still here, then he must have intended to observe things from a secure location.

Vertin: Is there a room in this facility where you might be able to monitor the entire exhibition center—somewhere secure?

Left: Excluding offline locations. Analyzing security and monitoring feasibility. Conclusion: the Power Control Room.

Vertin: Do we have some way to check if he's there?

Left: Affirmative, provided the communication system linking these locations is not damaged.

Left attempts to contact the power control room. After several failures, the connection goes through.

Left: Are you there, Comrade Maxim?

There is no response from the other end of the line.

Left: We must conclude that your attack on this facility and the staff here has some specific purpose or goal. Are you willing to open negotiations?

...

P-3: No response. Maybe he's not home?

Left: Comrade, you should be warned that—

Vertin: Maxim, we've been to your hideout. We know you were there recently.

Vertin: We saw things from your childhood there: your belongings, the toys you played with, even your family photos.

Vertin: A woman there, Tamara, told us your real name is Vanya.

Maxim: I recognize your voice, Dr. Vertin, I presume.

Maxim: You're wasting your time, and you don't have a lot of that left.

Maxim: You're about to get what you deserve—every single one of you drooling lackeys of that hack Sechenov. I'm not going anywhere, so if you're planning to kill me, do it. But it won't stop a damned thing.

The line cuts out.

P-3: This guy's got a death wish. What's he planning?

Vertin: Whatever it is, he's made it clear where to find him—the power control room.

There's a sudden burst of commotion from the huddle of survivors.

Ethan Brown: Hey! Alexei! Stay with me, pal! Somebody, please! He needs help!

Alexei: ...

In a corner, a familiar scientist holds on to his shaking friend.

P-3: I'm here! What's happening?

Ethan Brown: I don't know. He's starting to seize up like the others.

Alexei: Tie me up. Don't let me ...

P-3: Ah, yeah, got it.

The two men lift the scientist and carry him off into the next room. They've barely left sight before the screams begin.

P-3 returns with a dark, haunted expression; the other scientist follows behind him, sagging low at the shoulders.

P-3: Crispy critters! Can't wait to get my hands on that son of a b***h.

P-3: Hold things down here for me, will ya, ladies? I'm about to carve a warpath straight to him.

Left & Right: Comrade Major, before he severed the connection, Maxim warned that killing him would not be sufficient to stop his plans. Perhaps further investigation is needed.

P-3: And what's your big idea? Wait around until all these eggheads crack?

Left & Right: It remains a matter of critical importance that we determine the nature of their neurological distress.

P-3 stops himself at the doorway, breathing out a long, harsh breath.

Alexei: Ugh!

The gallery has fallen silent, punctuated sporadically by muffled screams echoing from the scientists tied up in the assembly shop.

Ethan Brown: Hold on. I think I have a theory.

P-3: Go on.

Ethan Brown: Alexei put on his device a little before I did. So, maybe these things are a kind of ticking time bomb? The longer you wear one, the more likely any little bump will set you off?

Ethan Brown: That could explain why it isn't happening all at once!

X reaches for the THOUGHT Device on his temple. He ponders things for a moment and then lets his hand fall.

Ethan Brown: But that means we're all in danger of going off without warning.

X: That includes me.

The others look to X with newfound concern for their colleague.

X: There's no reason to think I'm immune. I polymerized myself and installed the device around the same time as they did.

Vertin: *sigh*

Mesmer Jr.: This wasn't the data we were hoping to collect.

There are harsher words resting on her tongue, but she bites them back.

Mesmer Jr.: I know you wanted a deeper understanding of this world, but why did you take such a massive risk? Think about the ramifications. You could lose your mind, or worse, your life.

Mesmer Jr.: This is an absolute disaster. I should never have let things get this far.

X: There's always a method to these things, Mesmer. We aren't finished yet.

X points at his THOUGHT Device.

X: Progress requires risk. We've always believed that.

X: As researchers, we discover truth through experimentation. Now, we have one critical piece of the puzzle and the minds to crack it.

Mesmer Jr.: Are you suggesting we try to dissect a THOUGHT Device to pinpoint how it causes these psychotic breaks?

X: Precisely.

The therapist takes a moment to weigh the risk before she agrees.

Mesmer Jr.: You're right. There's no use complaining now. We have an opportunity to make the most of the time we have left.

P-3: You're kidding me? We're going to rely on a couple of teenagers to fix this? Nah. F**k that! Back to Plan A. I'm gonna go beat the answers out of Maxim.

Vertin: Wait, Major, the people here need you.

Vertin: Besides, he already made his intentions clear; he'll die before telling us anything. We have to solve this problem ourselves.

Vertin: What's more, it seems your companion is the only one here with any working knowledge of the THOUGHT Device. We'll need his help.

P-3: Someone still needs to get him before he causes more trouble.

Vertin: Then allow me to go. As a neutral party, I might have a better chance to negotiate with him.

P-3: Are you insane?

P-3: This is a life-or-death operation, kid, not a field trip. I'm not about to let you walk out there and get torn apart by those robots.

Left: We will not let that happen, Comrade Major.

Mesmer Jr. and X have put on hazmat suits and safety goggles borrowed from the assembly room, ready to start the experiment.

Mesmer Jr.: I know it may be hard to believe, but we're trained researchers. I was practically raised in the lab.

X: We may have come here under false pretenses, but we're proven and capable scientists. We can handle this.

Mesmer Jr. and X nod in unison and begin working on the THOUGHT Device.

P-3: I guess that means the summit's back on.

The Dreadful Truth

PD-10

Vertin: ...

The Twins run along a damaged corridor, followed by the visitor and the repurposed Belyash.

Left: The power control room is up this staircase. We must travel another 80 meters forward, turn left, and then reach the room at the end of the corridor.

Left: Our present speed may not be sufficient given the threat Maxim poses to the facility. Comrade, would you allow me to carry you?

Vertin: *panting* If that's what's needed.

The sleek robot bends down to scoop the visitor into her arms and then launches into a forward sprint.

A crash of scraping metal thunders above them.

Left: Structural failure imminent. Please, brace for impact.

Left: The sudden lockdown of that doorway is unlikely to have been accidental. Maxim may be aware of our approach.

Vertin: *cough*

Left: Comrade Doctor, are you hurt?

Vertin: *cough* I'm fine. It's only the dust.

Left: Apologies, comrade. I will attempt to warn you should I perform a slide of that nature in the future.

Vertin: It's quite alright. Let's just keep moving.

There's another thundering sound above them, but this one is different, like heavy footsteps.

Right: Warning: large heat signature approaching from above.

A heavily armed Belyash drops down through the ceiling.

Right stands in front of Left, shielding their companion from the debris.

Left: Scanning ... Heavy firepower detected. Another Belyash variant adapted by Maxim.

Left: Defensive matrixes engaged.

A temporary lab has been built in the corner of the assembly shop.

Mesmer Jr.: We have two unused THOUGHT Devices to examine before we poke around in anyone's head.

Char-les: Let me see them.

P-3 reaches out his gloved hand toward Mesmer Jr. so Char-les can interact with the THOUGHT Devices directly.

Char-les: Hmm. This device appears to be around three grams heavier than its technical specifications.

P-3: Go on then. Let's poke around inside.

Char-les: As you say, Major.

Char-les's tentacles inspect the device and find a narrow gap between the shell and the plate.

click The shell splits open.

Char-les: That is unusual.

Char-les raises the shell with two tentacles, displaying its insides to the others.

Char-les: This residue shouldn't be here.

X: Hmm, I do believe we've discovered our smoking gun.

P-3: So, what is it?

X: See that? Something broke apart when we opened it up, spilling out this gunk.

Char-les: Allow me to conduct a quick analysis. Hmm. It's a synthetic compound, a dissolving capsule made of polymer-soluble material with a biogel inside.

Char-les: Oh, I understand now.

P-3: Understand what? Enough with the suspense!

Char-les: Simply put, I believe Maxim inserted a capsule of polymer-soluble material into these THOUGHT Devices.

Char-les: Once it makes contact with the user's own polymer, the capsule begins to degrade, breaking with time or pressure until it releases its contents directly into their bloodstream.

P-3: Make it simple for me, Chuck.

Char-les: It's a poisonous time bomb.

P-3: So, when it goes off, it shoots a crazy pill straight into their brains?

Char-les: We'll need to do further tests to determine its full effects, but it's possible that the toxin may ultimately be fatal.

Mesmer Jr.: We don't have time for empty speculation, gentlemen. May I take a look?

Their investigation continues.

P-3 stands tapping his foot, impatiently craning his neck away from the operation table. He's been reduced from soldier to Char-les's glorified lab chair.

P-3: We done yet? I'm getting a cramp standing like this.

Char-les: Almost. Hold me higher. I can't see the screen.

P-3: Yeah, yeah. What'd I do to deserve this? I should be out there smashing heads.

Char-les: You are a vital asset to this operation, Major. I couldn't have done this without you.

P-3: Aww gee. You're gonna make me tear up, Char-les.

Mesmer Jr.: I think I've isolated the substance. Do you recognize this molecular structure, X?

X: No. It could be that this molecular structure is unique to the science of this world. Maybe we can preserve a sample for study back at Laplace.

Mesmer Jr.: You do understand your life may depend on this, don't you?

Mesmer Jr.: Is there a chemist here? We're having trouble identifying this substance.

Ethan Brown: I can help! I have a doctorate in medicinal biochemistry.

Mesmer Jr.: You did seem to be an expert in intoxicants. Have you sobered up yet?

Ethan Brown: Call me a drunk if you like, but I'm a drunk that got invited to this international summit. Now show me the damned report.

Ethan Brown: Hmm, I thought you said you were scientists? This one is almost trivial. Even a high schooler could identify it.

Ethan Brown: Oh, but this is a tricky one! Hmm. Its structure looks similar to adamantane.

Ethan Brown: It's a novel kind of synthetic neurotoxin. Quite brilliant, in fact. Maxim could have gotten a patent certificate from the Discovery and Invention Committee.

Mesmer Jr.: Focus, please. You're all in serious danger.

Ethan Brown: I can make a list of compounds that may help neutralize the toxin, but there's no way to guarantee anything.

Ethan Brown: In an ideal clinical environment, we would run trials to determine effective antidotes. Are there any lab animals here?

X: *sigh* If only we'd invited Medicine Pocket along.

Mesmer Jr.: I doubt we'll be able to find any living animals here. We'll have to test the reactivity on blood samples. Maybe we can collect it from the scientists that have died?

Char-les: I would advise against that. There are too many variables in testing blood from deceased subjects. We need living cellular tissue.

P-3: Hold on a minute. Isn't there an obvious fix for all of this?

Char-les: Major, I assure you if there were, we would have thought of it before now.

P-3: Hear me out. Why don't we just rip these things off of everyone's head before they can release the poison?

Mesmer Jr.: Absolutely not.

X: Maxim accounted for that particular possibility, unfortunately. The capsule is purposefully fragile. Once it's been connected, any kind of tampering with the device is likely to break it early.

X: It's an ingenious trap.

Char-les: You see, Major. It's too risky. We could end up hastening their descent into madness rather than saving them.

Mesmer Jr.: Simply put, we'd do more harm than good.

P-3: Okay, got it. Just figured I'd make sure we weren't missing the obvious.

P-3: Now what? Do we just hope no one dies between now and whenever we can round up some guinea pigs?

X: Actually, Major, you might just have inspired me. In absentia of any cavia porcellus, we do have the next best thing.

Mesmer shoots a sudden frown at X, already guessing at his plan.

Mesmer Jr.: You're crazy.

X: We extract a reduced dosage of the neurotoxin and inject it into me. Then we test out the antidotes systematically until one works.

Mesmer Jr.: *sigh* You already sound insane.

Symptoms

PD-11

P-3: Gutsy move. But are you sure about this, kid?

P-3: Besides, how do we know your device hasn't already triggered? If we inject more of that stuff into you, even an antidote might not be enough.

X: It's the best solution I can see. Given I only became polymerized earlier today, I should be especially sensitive to a polymer-based poison. My reaction will be easiest to observe in small, controlled doses.

X: It's what Madam Lucy would do.

Mesmer Jr.: No, it isn't. She would never approve of such an irresponsible act of self-sacrifice. Nor will I.

Mesmer Jr.: Let's just hope that Vertin can convince Maxim to give up an antidote.

Mesmer Jr.: I won't allow you to gamble your life on this while there is still a chance to find the solution another way.

Their argument has drawn the attention of the still-sane scientists.

Ethan Brown: Sorry, miss. But I think your colleague is right. Dangerous as his plan is, we don't have time to wait. Every minute that passes, more of us could be exposed.

Mesmer Jr.: Ugh. This is exactly what I was afraid of, X. Your irresponsible nature is practically infectious.

Mesmer Jr.: You just had to drag this whole world down with that special brand of arcanist madness.

X: Hold on, Mesmer. I didn't set off this chain of events. Call me a mad scientist if you like, but I don't deserve the blame for what's happening here.

Mesmer Jr.: I don't care who's to blame. I still won't let you do this to yourself.

Ethan Brown: This isn't the time to argue, kids. Maybe you're infecting me with "arcane madness," or maybe the poison already got to my head. Doesn't matter.

Ethan Brown: I'll do it. I'll be your guinea pig.

Ethan Brown: Besides, I've put myself through regular trials of intoxication for most of my life. What's another neurotoxin?

Mesmer Jr.: Eh, that's not the point!

Ethan Brown: No. It's not. The point is that I'm not letting a kid put himself on the line on my account.

Ethan Brown: My vision's starting to get blurry. Good bet I'm already exposed. So, let's get on with it.

Mesmer Jr.: Ugh. If that's the case, we may as well try. But I'm not happy with it.

Scientist VI: Alright, nice and tight.

After confirming that Ethan is securely tied, Mesmer Jr. takes out an injector that she brought from Laplace. Using a familiar tool makes her feel a little more at ease.

Ethan Brown: Hey, kid. You don't have to do this yourself if you don't agree. It's a simple injection.

Mesmer Jr.: Shush. I'm the only other person here with medical experience.

Mesmer Jr.: I would never have allowed anyone to do this back home. I guess I'm the mad scientist now.

Mesmer Jr. stabs the needle into Ethan's arm, pushing the plunger down in a slow, even release.

Mesmer Jr.: Hm. Your body temperature is rising, likely a reaction to the toxin or the antidote.

Mesmer Jr.: How do you feel?

Ethan Brown: My limbs are numb, and my eyes are losing focus. Feels like I'm staring up at the northern lights.

Mesmer Jr.: First antidote, not working. We'll observe you over the next five minutes and then try the next one.

X: Mesmer ...

Mesmer Jr.: What now? We're doing what you wanted, aren't we? Just leave me to my work.

Mesmer Jr. tries not to lose her temper as she looks back at X.

X: The antidotes could react to each other if applied on the same subject, so why not try the next one on me?

X: It's about time. I'm beginning to experience symptoms: diplopia, nausea, the works.

Mesmer Jr.: You'd better come back with a solution, Vertin.

The Belyash that crashed through the ceiling is now lying on the ruins it created.

Right: Combat concluded. No signs of injury or damage. We should return to our mission, comrades.

Left: ...

It's at this moment that she notices a slight inconsistency between the Twins' movements.

Vertin: Left? Are you alright?

Left: Running diagnostic.

Vertin: Are you hurt?

Left: Negative. Test complete. All systems functioning. We can proceed.

Left: The breach in the ceiling will allow us to compensate for lost time.

Left: Transport mode activated.

Left sweeps her companion into her arms again, preparing to jump up from the Belyash's remains.

Left: Again, please brace for impact.

Vertin: Not to worry. I feel quite safe in your arms.

Left: I am pleased to hear that, Comrade Doctor.

Left nods at her companion. She then jumps nimbly through the hole in the ceiling to reach the second floor.

The warning lights flash as the airtight door creaks open, illuminating the power control room.

Left: Please be careful, comrade. We advise you to stay outside of the room until it is secured.

Maxim: Hah. That must be why Sechenov always preferred the company of robots—always ready to sacrifice themselves for the good of humanity.

Left: ...

Maxim sits relaxedly in a soft chair in front of the instrument panel.

Maxim: I wonder what you really think. Do you see other robots as your "people"?

Maxim: Does that emotion module of yours prick with doubt or pain when you see your kind die?

Left: We are not obligated to answer your questions, Maxim.

Maxim: Oh, I suppose the real question is, can a robot truly even die? *sigh* That's a question that would have fascinated me when I was younger.

Vertin: Maxim, what did you do to the THOUGHT Devices?

Maxim: What makes you think I would tell you?

Maxim stands up, fixing his wrinkled trousers.

Vertin: I'm not from here. I don't know what Kollektiv 2.0 means to you or to this country. I just want to understand.

Vertin: You expressed concerns about it before. Maybe you think the world would be better off without it. I don't know, but what I do know is that what you've done here is wrong.

Vertin: Whatever the intention was, it wasn't worth killing innocent people.

Maxim: "Whatever the intention," hmph, you're more right than you know, young lady.

A huge robot with a round belly appears behind Maxim.

Maxim: But I'm not special—making ends justify the means—that's just the way we do things here. Haven't you figured that out?

The robot is torn apart, its components scattering all over the floor. Sparks pop from its torn wiring, lighting Maxim's dispirited face.

Left: Target down. Area secured.

Vertin: Please, Maxim, tell us, is there an antidote or at least some way to prevent exposure?

Maxim: Is that your best effort? Heheh. The Argentum Unit would have at least brought truth serum.

Vertin: If you were trying to stop Kollektiv 2.0 from launching, you already succeeded. There's no way they'll release it on schedule after everything that happened here.

Vertin: Do more people really need to die just to make this a bigger scandal?

Maxim: ...

Maxim places one hand on his temple, pondering, then lets it fall to his side.

Maxim: Sechenov deserves every punishment coming to him, but you're right. I never wanted people to suffer in vain.

Maxim: There is an antidote.

Left: Abnormal heart rhythm detected. Comrade Doctor, be careful. He may be engaging in deception.

Vertin: It's alright.

Vertin: Please, Maxim. Just share it with us.

Maxim: It's a simple antidote. Though I'm afraid I'll be taking the first dose.

He draws a pistol out of his pocket.

Maxim: One shot of lead to end the suffering of a hopeless man in this hopeless country!

Vertin: Maxim! No!

Retro-Futurism

PD-12

Scientist VII: Ugh ... Ugh ...

One by one, the other scientists volunteer themselves. They come wordlessly and resigned to do or die for the good of all the others. The only sound in the room is the dull moaning of the insane.

Mesmer Jr. crosses another item off her list. There's been no sign of improvement from any attempt yet.

Mesmer Jr.: Atropine, benactyzine, pralidoxime ... We've almost tried everything.

Mesmer Jr.: Maybe obidoxime? We'd have to be extremely careful with the dose.

Scientist VIII: It worked! We've found it!

Mesmer Jr. bolts upright at the exclamation, though she balances optimism and pessimism as she follows the voice to its source.

Scientist VIII: The sixth antidote worked! Subject Six has regained consciousness!

P-3: Crispy critters! Finally!

Mesmer Jr.: Don't celebrate yet! It could be terminal lucidity! We'll need to observe him a little longer, but we can start preparing his antidote for the others.

Mesmer Jr.: If we determine it's effective, we'll start treatment in order of severity and length of seizure.

Mesmer Jr.'s commands are carried out immediately. Soon, the first group of patients regains consciousness.

X: Phew. That's an immediate amelioration of symptoms. I think we've found our winner.

X: It's strange. I can almost feel the polymer reacting inside me.

Mesmer Jr.: It's possible that you're more sensitive to the treatment, just like you predicted.

X: I think you may have saved my life, Mesmer.

Mesmer Jr.: Just don't ever make me have to do this for you again. No more random injections, got it?

X: That's asking a lot for a Laplace researcher, don't you think?

Mesmer Jr.: This isn't Laplace. You really can be insufferable sometimes.

Mesmer Jr.: What happened to the power?

Mesmer Jr.: Is anyone using a respirator? Get them on a backup immediately.

Scientist VI: It's not the power. Everything's still running.

Broadcast: Self-destruct sequence activated. Countdown: 15 minutes.

Mesmer Jr.: Self-destruct sequence?

Broadcast: Mesmer Jr. and little X, Mesmer Jr. and little X, your parent is waiting for you at the power control room. Repeat: Your parent is waiting for you at the power control room.

Mesmer Jr.: Huh?

X: That has to be Vertin. She might be in trouble. I guess we'll have to go find our "parent."

The half-mad scientist sits up and unties the ropes around his body while his colleague rolls her eyes.

Mesmer Jr.: Looks like I don't need to worry about your condition. Are you sure you're ready for action?

X: Absolutely! Just as long as you don't expect me to be as dexterous as the Twins.

Mesmer Jr.: But what about the other patients?

P-3: We've got things handled here. We've even got the drunk back on his feet. Just go!

Right: Tereshkova has sent out a broadcast to your colleagues.

Right: A large number of Maxim's robots appear to be leaving their patrol routes.

Right: Given the circumstances, any attempt at evacuation will be a significant risk. Should we proceed?

Vertin: We have to do whatever we can to preserve lives.

Right: Understood. I will attempt to locate suitable vehicles within the facility.

Left: Comrade Doctor, your friends will arrive in ...

Left: Three, two, one.

Left opens the door, allowing two Laplace researchers to tumble inside. They look singed and smell of burning metal. As the door closes, a horde of violent robots slams up against the heavy door.

Mesmer Jr.: What's this about a self-destruct sequence, Vertin? Where's Maxim?

Her eyes follow a glance down to the floor. Maxim lies in a pool of scarlet blood. A hole is pierced through his temple. His hand is still clutching the instrument of his demise.

Vertin: I couldn't stop him. The sequence was activated as soon as he died.

Left: It appears that Maxim programmed a tripwire into the facility's self-destruct protocols.

Left: The only way to abort the procedure is to enter the administrator password, which has been altered. Speculation—

Mesmer Jr.: And only Maxim knows the password.

Mesmer Jr. moves her eyes from Maxim to her companion and immediately connects why she is needed here.

Mesmer Jr.: I may be able to use Artificial Somnambulism to extract information from his dying brain matter. But there is a complication.

She needs not state the obvious to anyone present—a bullet went through his head.

Mesmer Jr.: Let's hope he didn't destroy his hippocampus.

X: He's been polymerized, right? We already saw that it preserves some measure of the individual's brain activity after death.

Mesmer Jr.: But we can't possibly predict how Artificial Somnambulism would interact with a technology like that.

Mesmer Jr.: And even so, we know that the polymer doesn't preserve life; it only extends a limited imprint. We can't be sure of the extent or even the stability of Maxim's memories.

Mesmer Jr.: Diving into a dead man's dreams ... Even if we were fully equipped, and we're not, we could still end up lost in it.

Vertin: Nevertheless, what other option do we have?

Mesmer Jr.: So, I'll play the mad scientist yet again. It's becoming a pattern working with you two. X, I'll need some improvised equipment; I'll make a list.

Mesmer Jr.: I don't care if they run on a hamster wheel or marbles running down a course. Just make them functional.

X: I'll facilitate your every expectation. Left, would you mind giving me a hand?

Left: Searching for keywords: Artificial Somnambulism. Zero results found. But I am at your service, Comrade Doctors.

Mesmer Jr.: First, we need a glass harmonica. Is there one here?

Left: Unfortunately, the Polymer Exhibition Hall does not contain any musical instruments of that variety.

Mesmer Jr.: But it's essential for Artificial Somnambulism. X, can you build it?

X: Sure. Give me four hours and a room the size of a football field.

Vertin: This isn't the time for jokes. Left, could you find a suitable substitute?

Left: Searching for exhibits with similar functions and potentially useful raw materials.

As if waiting for the most dramatic moment, the repair vendor in the corner reactivates, bathing the room in red scanner light.

NORA: Sounds like you could use a little assistance.

NORA: I can make you a glass harmonica, just so long as you give me what I need.

Vertin: NORA? I thought you were out of commission.

NORA: Truth be told. I've been trying to get out of this place since the self-destruct sequence started. But I'm trapped here, alone and unloved!

NORA: *sigh* If only some handsome hero were around to carry me to safety. But since I don't want to die surrounded by a bunch of brats, how about you help a girl out and feed me?

Vertin: We'll need as much glass as we can find.

In no time at all, X has managed to direct the construction of an awkward but functional glass harmonica, though the various parts nearly fill up the entire room.

Left: Your intuitive grasp of technology is astounding, Comrade Doctor. I have made a recording of your process for future reference.

Mesmer Jr.: I know I said you could make it any way you like, but will this thing really work?

X: I'm positively certain! It's an unorthodox design, I know, but the physics are sound.

Mesmer Jr.: I'll take your word for it. Now, who's going to dive into Maxim's dream?

NORA: Ugh. I wouldn't dare be caught with such a hideous man. That hole in his head was practically an improvement.

X: Me! Let me try!

Mesmer Jr.: No. You're the only one who can fix the machine if anything happens.

The number of candidates dwindles.

Vertin: I'll go. I have experienced dream diving.

Left: You may require the assistance of someone familiar with polymer-based technology. With your permission, I will accompany you, comrade.

X: It should be possible to send you both. I've created an interface on the device that Left can plug into directly.

Mesmer Jr.: I suggest against it. We can't afford to lose both of you.

Vertin: Your concern is noted, Ms. Mesmer, but the risks are greater if either of us goes alone.

Mesmer Jr.: I'm going to need a long vacation after this.

Mesmer Jr.: Vertin, put the helmet on. Left, plug in. There may be a brief tingling sensation, but don't panic. It won't last.

Left: A tingling?

Mesmer Jr.: Yes, one of the side effects of Artificial Somnambulism.

Left: Understood. Ready to connect.

Vertin: We trust you, Mesmer Jr., X.

X: Appreciated, Vertin. I'll fortify the room as best as I can. We should be able to hold out for now.

Mesmer Jr.: Alright, I'll guide you in.

Trapped in "Limbo"

PD-13

Child: Mama, when will you be back?

Doctor: Before you know it, Vanya.

Child: Will I see you tomorrow? Mama? Mama?

Maxim's Subconsciousness

Mesmer Jr.: Can you hear me, Vertin?

Mesmer Jr.: As I feared, the dream is unstable. There's abnormal data mixed in with Maxim's fading memories.

Mesmer Jr.: I presume it's coming from the polymer.

It's a strange, dilapidated room. Through the doorway, it seems to lead to another seemingly identical room, and then another, and another, as though it were a maze of mirrors.

Vertin: I hear you, Mesmer. I think the room I'm in must be Maxim's home.

Mesmer Jr.: This dream is likely to be different from anything you've ever handled before. I don't know what lies ahead.

Vertin: I'll be ready. Just keep things running up there.

A stately grandfather clock tolls in the time, and with it, a woman appears by the dining table.

Rozaliya: Hurry up, Vanya.

Maxim: ...

Maxim trudges through the doorway and sits down at the table, not as a child, but as a full-grown man.

Rozaliya: You'll have to head straight to school after breakfast. Remember what I told you?

Maxim: ...

Rozaliya: "Wash your hands, keep your mask on, and apply disinfectant as soon as you get home." That's right!

The woman holds up another finger with each reminder. It's the gentle sing-song instruction of a mother to her young child—completely oblivious to his apparent age.

After that, the woman turns to the sink and goes through the motions of washing a dish, yet there is nothing in her hands. A moment later, she answers an unheard question.

Rozaliya: No. Mama probably won't be home tonight, neither will Papa.

Rozaliya: Have you finished? Off to school then. Let the teachers know right away if you feel ill, understood?

The woman removes her apron and dons a doctor's coat as she bids Maxim a simple, affectionate goodbye.

As she leaves, Maxim rises from his seat and stretches toward the grandfather clock. He pulls delicately on the minute hand, forcing it back counterclockwise.

Rozaliya: Hurry up, Vanya.

Maxim re-enters from the same door and sits at the dining table again.

Everything proceeds just as it had before, a repeated moment, frozen in time.

Left: This subliminal space bears notable similarities to Limbo.

Vertin: Limbo? Like in the *Divine Comedy*?

Left: The name was chosen based on its similarity to the liminal spiritual realm. We use it to refer to subconscious spaces generated by polymerized individuals.

Left: It appears that this bears a strong resemblance to the space created by your Artificial Somnambulism device.

Left: However, it is not clear if this space is in fact Limbo, or a dream, or some reflection of them both.

Maxim does not react to their conversation, nor indeed even to his mother.

He simply returns to the clock, time after time, winding the moment back.

Mesmer Jr.: We're on a deadline, remember. We need to induce Maxim to recall his password.

Mesmer Jr.: But try not to push him too hard. There's no telling what additional stress might do to the dream state. We're already operating in the margins.

Mesmer Jr.: Maybe start by collecting clues from the surroundings.

Vertin: This moment must be from Maxim's childhood. Do you have any idea what's going on?

Left: Speculation: This appears to be during the early months of the Plague. During this time, hospitals were overloaded, and doctors were often forced to work long hours isolated in quarantine zones.

As they talk, the clock's hands suddenly speed up, fast-forwarding the scene in the room until it chimes again.

dong

Maxim still sits at the dining table, staring out into the void.

Vertin: Do you hear that?

Left: They're announcing funerals, Comrade Doctor.

Maxim: ...

Maxim turns toward the door, his face expressionless and hollow. Cries seem to come from all sides of the room.

Andrey: Come here, Vanya. Don't be afraid.

A man resembling Maxim crouches in front of him, hugging an invisible figure.

Vertin: That must be Maxim's father.

Andrey: Your mama is fine. I got a call from her earlier. She's just too busy to come home.

Andrey: You know, your mama is very brave. She is doing a great service for us all. Someone must go to the hospitals and take care of all the sick.

Andrey: I know you miss her, so do I, but there are others that need her more than we do now.

Andrey speaks gently to the invisible figure.

Andrey: Now, your papa has a job to do too. So, you must stay here and take good care of yourself until we get back.

Andrey: Don't worry about me, son. I'll send our little robot round to say hi whenever I can.

The man produces a small robot from his pocket. It looks identical to the one in Maxim's family photo.

Andrey: That sickness has hurt many people, but your papa will do something to stop it.

Andrey: Since robots never get sick, we'll have them keep the world spinning.

Andrey: That is how we will save our land and our people.

Andrey passes the invisible figure the little robot, though it disappears as soon as it leaves his hand.

Andrey: Promise me you'll take good care of yourself, Vanya.

Left: The number of deaths had already exceeded 20 million at this point. Soviet society was on the verge of collapse.

Left: And the death toll continued to rise until Dr. Sechenov helped to invent the Redemption vaccine using his polymer.

Maxim: Heh.

Maxim at last seems to react to their presence, though he does not turn to face them.

Andrey leaves, and the clock's hands speed up once more. Maxim returns to the dining table.

knock The door opens. Two men in protective suits enter the room. Before they say anything, that same near-invisible presence rushes over to hug them. Yet they seem to push it away.

Government Employee: You're mistaken, comrade. We're not your parents.

They seem to have heard something and look at each other.

Government Employee: Listen, son, can you gather up your family's papers? Then you'll need to come with us.

Government Employee: Your parents ... They, um ...

Government Employee: Anyway, just follow us. We'll take you to them. Quickly.

Drawers open and close in rapid succession as the presence seems to follow their orders. After the last one is closed, the two men escort the invisible child outside.

The clock stops ticking.

Vertin: I think that might be all that's left of his memories.

Maxim at last turns to face them, though he gives them only a single empty glance before he staggers back toward the grandfather clock. This time, however, one of them stands in his way.

Maxim: Who are you people?! Leave me alone!

Vertin: Maxim, you can still save lives before it's too late. It's time to let go.

Maxim: ...

Maxim: Why?

Tableware: Why?

Maxim's voice booms out everywhere and all at once. Even the knives and forks on the table clatter with his voice.

Tableware: The day I left with those men, I saw my neighbor hugging her mother. She was back from the hospital. I remember they had a robot carrying their suitcases, one just like my father made.

Tableware: She survived. She didn't leave her child alone.

Tableware: Why me?

Tableware: Why my family?! It isn't right!

Tableware: My mother had saved her!

Little Robot: My father made the robots that took care of them.

Tableware & Little Robot: But they didn't get to come home.

Little Robot: They left me alone. All I had to remember them were the tattered medals the government gave me on their behalf.

Tableware: I never learned where they were buried. They could be lying in some unknown, unmarked pit or burned away to ash!

Vertin: I know all too well how painful it can be to accept your loved ones' sacrifice. But we have a responsibility to ensure their deaths were not in vain.

The tableware and the little robot collapse suddenly.

Maxim: A few memorials, a few medals, then things changed. People stopped remembering. They started saying that it was the Kollektiv that saved them.

Maxim: That's right! The Kollektiv. Hahaha .... The Kollektiv.

Maxim: What a glorious, heartwarming name! It brings to mind all of those soldiers marching in lockstep in the celebratory parades.

Maxim: Thud, thud, thud! "Behold our march to the future, comrades! We will build a new world forged by our hands! Aren't we all so proud of the 'collective'!"

Maxim: People's heads became filled with these lies. They forgot all that we had gone through, or maybe they just wanted to forget. Then the monuments changed. Suddenly they all had his face—his name.

Maxim: There was no room for any others. Names became mere statistics. Mothers and fathers, children; dead and forgotten in their millions. But not him. He was "Dr. Sechenov, inventor of polymer, savior of the Soviet Union."

Maxim: Over and over, all the glory, all the praise, everything went to him and his damned polymer.

Maxim twists, kicking the dining table with enough force to rattle the dishes.

Maxim: How can that be? Why does he live when they had to die? How can we go blindly into this world he created?

Maxim: Their graves were just stepping stones on his march of progress.

Maxim: Men like Sechenov only look forward to their "bright and limitless future." To them, the sooner the dead are forgotten, the better.

Vertin: That isn't true, Maxim.

Vertin: Of course, the ones that survive should mourn and honor those they lost. But we also have to move on. Not to forget, but to build again.

Vertin: You let yourself be trapped in the shadow of your loss, but I know your parents wouldn't have wanted that for you.

Maxim: Don't tell me what they'd think!

Black smoke billows out from Maxim's body as it begins to fall apart before their eyes. The inky smoke coalesces and takes on human forms.

Maxim: It's easy for people like you to say that—to pretend that a few kind words are enough to bury the dead.

Maxim: But then you praise the man that took everything from them. It isn't fair!

A Drop in the Ocean

PD-14

Maxim: *choke*

Countless Chirpers fall like raindrops, each playing a different voice.

Doctor?: I have a son your age. Maybe you two can play together when you're feeling better.

Maxim: Uggh. No, no ...

Maxim flails outward, trying to catch the Chirpers as they fall, but each one passes through his fingers in vain.

Engineer?: This is a fine gadget, don't you think? Maybe we should install it in our robot's head.

Young Woman?: We're so very grateful. Thank you! Thank you for not abandoning us!

Maxim: No, no, no, no!

One of the Chirpers reflects in the dark pools of his eyes.

Maxim: Papa, Mama?

Rozaliya: Vanya, has our country survived?

Maxim: Yes, Mama. People are even growing flowers again. I picked your favorites. But I couldn't bring them to your funeral.

Rozaliya: Are you taking good care of yourself?

Maxim: I ...

Rozaliya: What is life like now? Are the people happy?

Maxim: Life is ...

Andrey: I wish I could see all the latest technology. What can robots do now?

Maxim buries his head in his hands, his voice muffled.

Maxim: It's all so wonderful, Papa, Mama. We stopped the Plague, and now we're going to explore the cosmos.

Andrey: And what of you, little Vanya? How have you contributed?

Maxim: Everything has gotten better. I wish you could see.

Andrey: We're just happy to know things are better now. Though I admit I am jealous of you.

Maxim: Shouldn't you be angry? They're enjoying this world because of you, but they don't even know your names. They don't know what you gave up for them, what I lost for them!

Andrey: Why should we be angry, son? All that we did was in the hopes that the future would be brighter for our people and for you.

Rozaliya: The future is yours now, Vanya. All we want is for you to make it a better place.

Andrey: Don't let us down.

Rozaliya: He won't. I know our little Vanya has grown into a good man.

Maxim: ...

The Chirper drops to the ground and disappears.

Maxim: No, no.

Maxim: Mama, Papa, don't go.

Vertin: They have to go, Maxim. That's just the way of things. But you can choose to let them inspire you instead of dragging you into despair.

Mesmer Jr.: Don't push too hard, Vertin. He needs time to process things.

Knees on the ground, Maxim bends over and cradles his head. His trembling fingers reach toward his temple.

Maxim: *crying* I want to go home.

Left: Warning: Data overflow detected. This space may be compromised, comrade.

Mesmer Jr.: She's right, Vertin. I'm reading a cortisol spike. You don't have much time before his brain activity shuts down!

Crack.

Crack. Crack.

Maxim's body begins to break apart. Streams of transparent fluid leak out from his forehead and then from everywhere else.

Maxim: I need to go home.

Mesmer Jr.: His dream state might collapse at any moment! You need to get out of there!

Vertin: Not without the password. Is there anything else we can do?

Mesmer Jr.: Absolutely not! Your safety is top priority! Find somewhere secure now! I'm dragging you out!

X: Wait. That fluid must be polymer. It might still have an imprint of his memories. It's our last chance!

There's a sudden burst of commotion from the huddle of survivors.

The leaking substance turns into a small flood, rising up to the ankles of the two intruders in his collapsing dream.

Vertin: If these are his memories, then where's the password?

Mesmer Jr.: Did you hear me, Vertin? Get out!

Vertin: Give me more time! I can still find it.

The rising fluid begins to cover the chest.

Left: Comrade Doctor, you must leave. I will continue the mission.

Vertin: What do you mean? How?

Left: My sensors and processing ability are more efficient than yours, comrade. I will have a higher chance of retrieving the password in the time we have left.

She generates an egg-shaped barrier to create a safe zone around her companion, parting the viscous fluid like the Red Sea.

She walks toward Maxim. The closer she gets, the higher the pressure on the barrier, causing its surface to crack.

Mesmer Jr.: Confirming Vertin's status. Operable! Disconnect!

Vertin: Wait! Hold on, no!

P-3: Damn, you actually made it. That's some good news at least.

Vertin: P-3? What are you doing here?

Right: We have disabled most of the facility's hostile robots, but we were unable to secure any vehicles suitable for an evacuation.

Right: Requesting synchronization.

Mesmer Jr.: Are you alright, Vertin?

Mesmer leans over to inspect her reckless colleague. X, meanwhile, is still nursing what looks to be an open-hand smack to his face—An unforeseen consequence of his suggestion.

Vertin: I'm alright, Mesmer. But Left is still inside.

Vertin: Before I got out, she ...

Right: Synchronization complete. Please allow me to provide help.

Right connects herself to the Artificial Somnambulism machine without hesitation.

Right: Warning: data ... overflow ...

Vertin: Left? Right?

Mesmer Jr.: W-What are they doing?

X: I believe this is their method of sharing computational power. Though the ballet aesthetic only serves as a personal affectation of the designer.

X: Watch out!

The Twins lie on the ground in a disjointed heap. Their bodies are charred.

There are still sparks popping out of the interfaces along their spines.

Left: Password and antidote composition secured.

As Left points at the control room's computer, the screen turns on and displays a message.

Broadcast: Self-destruct sequence terminated.

Mesmer Jr.: Phew ...

Mesmer leans back against the wall and allows herself to sink down to the ground, where she inadvertently presses on the muzzle of X's modified gun.

click

The familiar sweet melody begins to chime from it, playing over the exhausted assembly.

Left: ...

As it does, the Twins begin to stir.

Vertin: What is it? Are you alright?

Left: That song ... My emotion module is experiencing a reaction to it.

Left: However, I am unable to discern the programming that explains this reaction.

Left: Has my programming been corrupted, or do I remember it from somewhere?

Left: Please, comrade. May I listen to it again?

Vertin: It's a beautiful song, isn't it? I suppose even a robot might find it touching.

Left: Touching, yes. Added to database.

Mesmer Jr.: Something's irked me this entire time. If the Twins were able to access Artificial Somnambulism, that must mean they have a consciousness. Perhaps they can even dream.

Left: Were we still within your Artificial Somnambulism, or was it only Limbo after all? Can I dream?

P-3: 'Course you can. Bots like you and Char-les gotta have feelings, right? Why else would he be such a pain in my ass?

P-3: Seems like a question for another time, though. You two should get yourselves repaired. I don't want the boss to blame me for you ladies falling apart.

P-3: Damn. There is something familiar about that song, isn't there?

Goodbye, Chelomey

PD-15

As the launch day of Kollektiv 2.0 nears, Chelomey is decked out in festive decorations, and the people pour into the streets to celebrate.

Chelomey Complex

The young visitors step out from the hospital after having been checked over and look out over the festivities.

Mesmer Jr.: Have all the survivors recovered?

X: Yeah. Seems like the government is still reeling from the diplomatic fracas, and they've locked down the Exhibition Hall. But the worst of it is over.

X: No news about the Twins though. I hope they're alright.

Vertin: They're actually coming to pick us up. Seems like Dr. Sechenov has already installed them into brand new bodies.

X: What about Maxim? How did they deal with him?

Vertin: I have no idea. Perhaps Dr. Sechenov will know.

Mesmer Jr.: Good. I have some questions for him too.

The young visitors walk toward a vehicle, where the Twins await them in that same ever-graceful pose. Sechenov looks out toward them through the vehicle's window.

Sechenov: If it isn't our young scientists! What a pleasure to get a chance to see you once again. If only I had time to sit and chat.

Vertin: It's good to see you as well, Dr. Sechenov.

Sechenov: I am dreadfully sorry to have dragged you into all this, comrades. Yet, I must commend you on your heroic efforts during this crisis. You saved many lives, and for that I am grateful. Would you allow me the honor of shaking your hands?

Sechenov shakes hands with each of them, his palm warm and firm, showing genuine care for the young visitors.

Sechenov: I've been wondering how I might reward you for all you've done.

Sechenov: I don't suppose you would be interested in studying here in the Soviet Union? I would be more than happy to organize some scholarships and accommodations.

Sechenov: You'll have promising careers in the Kollektiv 2.0 project after you graduate. A bright, limitless future awaits!

Vertin: Of course, we're extremely grateful for the offer. Unfortunately, we have to return to our home soon.

The visitors pause and look at each other.

Mesmer Jr.: Dr. Sechenov, I must be frank. We're deeply concerned about the safety of Kollektiv 2.0 after these events. Are you really going to proceed with the launch?

The academician thinks for a moment before he answers.

Sechenov: Naturally, this Maxim incident has forced us to look deeply into the security of the network. There are no words to express my regret in not anticipating these possible security issues earlier.

Sechenov: But we've analyzed the risks thoroughly. My colleagues are already hard at work closing the system backdoors that were used, and we've built in an early warning system to detect similar attempts in the future.

Sechenov: I'm entirely confident that these measures will allow Kollektiv 2.0 to launch without any further risk. But we cannot step back from the march of progress. The potential benefits to our people and our nation's development demand we press onwards.

Apparently, the "incident" has not shaken Sechenov's confidence in his invention.

X: The march of progress. Hmm, I admit it will be a revolutionary paradigm shift, if it works.

"If" hangs in the air like a lit fuse, said with all of the confidence that one might change the earth's rotation.

Sechenov: Of course it will. We stand on the threshold of a perfect society, the goal of my life's work and that of every Soviet scientist.

His answer makes it clear he has no intention of justifying himself further. Their questions die unspoken.

Vertin: One more thing, Dr. Sechenov. It's about Maxim.

Sechenov sighs.

Sechenov: His body has been taken care of. As for the loose ends, we're still discussing the matter internally. I hope to find a resolution that satisfies everyone.

Sechenov: The question remains how he accomplished this attack. Someone must have backed his play for their own purposes, and I suspect I know who.

Sechenov: Molotov and I have always had differences. Oh, my apologies. It's nothing to trouble you with. Please, enjoy the celebration.

Sechenov: You must excuse me for not accompanying you further. But I'm sure you understand I have a busy schedule ahead.

Vertin: We appreciate your hospitality. Goodbye, Dr. Sechenov.

Sechenov: Goodbye, young scientists. I look forward to hearing about your future achievements!

The vehicle drives away to avoid being completely surrounded. The trio is forced to dodge into an alley to get away from the frantic crowd.

P-3: Hey! Over here!

Vertin: Huh?

P-3's voice booms from the riverside, where a Drofa drone is serving him a glass of soda.

P-3: Hah. This celebration's not too shabby, honestly. You kids wanna have some fun before you head out?

A Drofa drone stops in front of the young visitors.

Vertin: Three sodas, please.

P-3: If I've got the memo right, the boss is going to give a big speech before the launch.

Another formation consisting of young people marches beneath them in unison, their faces serious.

X: What's that formation?

P-3: Err, let me see. The banner says "Families of Fallen Heroes."

P-3: "In memory of those who sacrificed everything for the Soviet Union."

Life ends. That much is clear to everyone, but in the cheering faces of the crowd, there is a promise: That those that came before pave the way for tomorrow.

Vertin: The sacrifices of one generation fuel the achievements of the next. Even if it takes many generations to get there, those dreams may still come true.

P-3: You oughta put that on a plaque, kid. Hah. Come on. Don't be so serious. Let's have a little music to lighten the mood, whaddya say?

X: Sounds good to me.

X points his music box gun at the sky and pulls the trigger—bang! A burst of colorful ribbons fires out in lieu of bullets, accompanied by the soft chime of the music box.

P-3: You rigged that up in the hospital? Gotta admit that's impressive.

P-3: I thought I was a firearms expert, but you managed to make a gun work better with just a music box. You gotta teach me your tricks.

X: Well, it's kind of a "patented" technique.

P-3 puts his arm around X's neck, jokingly attempting to make him surrender his "patent."

Vertin: They seem to be getting along well.

Mesmer Jr.: Typical boys.

Mesmer Jr.: I still find myself thinking about how Left reacted to this song.

Mesmer Jr.: I wonder what it means to her.

P-3: It's a real beauty. Kinda song you might play before you propose to a girl.

He gives up on squeezing the secret out of X, clearly interested in the topic of the song.

P-3: What's it called?

Char-les: That would be *Waltz of the Flowers*, Major.

P-3: Yeah, figures it'd be something like that. Can't shake the feeling I've heard it somewhere. No clue where, though.

Char-les: It is a popular song. I wouldn't be surprised if you had heard it before.

P-3: Nah, it's more than that. It's sticking to me, like it meant something to me before I lost my memory.

P-3: Maybe I really did propose to someone with that song.

Char-les: I can only imagine they chose the song then.

While P-3 falls into a distracted conversation with Char-les, X manages to escape from his grasp and sneak back to his friends.

X: I think our experiment is coming to an end.

As a gun salute sounds, countless balloons fly into the sky, and a great cheer goes up from the crowd.

Little Girl: Mama! That's my balloon!

Middle-Aged Woman: Which one?

Little Girl: Umm. I don't know which one, but where are they going?

Middle-Aged Woman: To the future.

Vertin: Have you decided on a souvenir for Madam Lucy?

X: Um, well ...

The Nature of Being

PD-16

X: Hm ...

Vertin: That is unexpected.

As the trio return from the stage, they notice that what they intended to bring has disappeared, and in its stead is a Chirper.

Lucy: Is this the hydrogen cell that you mentioned?

Lucy: It does have a very unique appearance for a power cell, though I take it that this may be a consequence of the alternate technology involved.

Mesmer Jr.: No. It's not a power cell. Just a talking pocket watch.

X: Ahaha! What a remarkable outcome! The object changed entirely during the transfer. I guess this is another fascinating aspect of the stage. An unaccounted variable, like the Butterfly Effect.

X: A hydrogen cell turned into a Chirper ... The science of that alone is worth studying, hah, don't you think?

Lucy: Indeed. I am immediately curious what effect the stage might have on my own body if I attempted to travel through it.

Lucy: Would my robotic shell change to fit the local culture and technology of the destination, just as it did Vertin's outfit?

X: Why not give it a try and find out? I can activate it again anytime. It's about time you took a vacation, Madam Lucy.

Left: Should you intend to visit again, I will make certain to register you as legal visitors.

Left and Right appear on the communicator's screen.

Lucy: Thank you for your offer, but I am afraid I have to decline.

Lucy: I believe our team is in need of an immediate physical examination after the events they have gone through, in particular, to determine the effects of a certain injection.

X: Ahaha, ah. Personally, I'm entirely intrigued by the possibility of keeping this polymer in my bloodstream.

Lucy: Your well-being is top priority in this particular matter, Researcher X.

X: Ah, can we make it short? The stage could change its destination anytime.

X: I don't want to ruin Madam Lucy's prospects for a vacation.

Mesmer Jr.: You'll need a thorough examination, I'm afraid. We can't run the risk that the polymer shifted during travel as well. You can tell Lucy all about our findings while you recuperate at the rehab center.

X: *sigh* Fine, fine. You're the boss.

Lucy: While I am intrigued by the prospect of traveling, the changing destinations of the stage do not follow fixed patterns. I am willing to "roll the dice," as you might say.

Mesmer Jr.: I'll get X to the rehab center and make sure he stays put. Why don't you spend some time here while you can, Madam Lucy?

The young visitors organize their reports and set off for the rehab center.

Soon the laboratory quiets down.

Left: There appears to be a strong rapport between you and your researchers.

Lucy: It pleases me to hear you say that. I will take that as a marked improvement of my understanding of humanitarianism.

Lucy: From my cursory reading of Vertin's report, I have already learned a great deal about your world.

Lucy: Despite running dozens of simulated scenarios, I still find it hard to pinpoint the divergence between our worlds' respective technological progression—another fascinating element of scientific discovery.

Right: Scientific development is often shaped by the demands of the environment. Perhaps the unique struggles of your world led to a divergence in technological need, just as they did in ours.

Lucy: If I have learned anything from humans, it is that their greatest motivation is and has always been survival. It is admirable even if it can lead science towards destructive paths.

Lucy: The greatest danger lies in giving up and dwelling in the mistakes of the past.

Lucy: I have lived through many generations of human technology and observed their progress firsthand. Setbacks and disasters are inevitable, but there will always be those willing to take risks to bring about a better world.

Lucy: Innovation is a process that feels in many ways like laying track before a speeding train. Too often, we only see the hazards ahead when it is too late to change course.

Lucy: But as long as humanity survives, they will learn from those harsh lessons and overcome.

Left: Analysis: Your theory of human progress bears a strong resemblance to the process of natural selection.

Lucy: Perhaps so. But the random dictates of genetic mutation are a much slower process. I have seen human innovation leapfrog eons of natural development within a single generation. I am excited to see where they will go next.

Lucy removes her human mask, revealing her expressionless metallic face beneath. Yet the red light pulses, pondering the future.

In that moment, standing on the bridge between two worlds, two forms of inorganic life discuss the very nature of being.